THE NEWS-PRESS
AUGUST 2004 | news-press.com/hurricane | COMMEMORATIVE EDITION



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

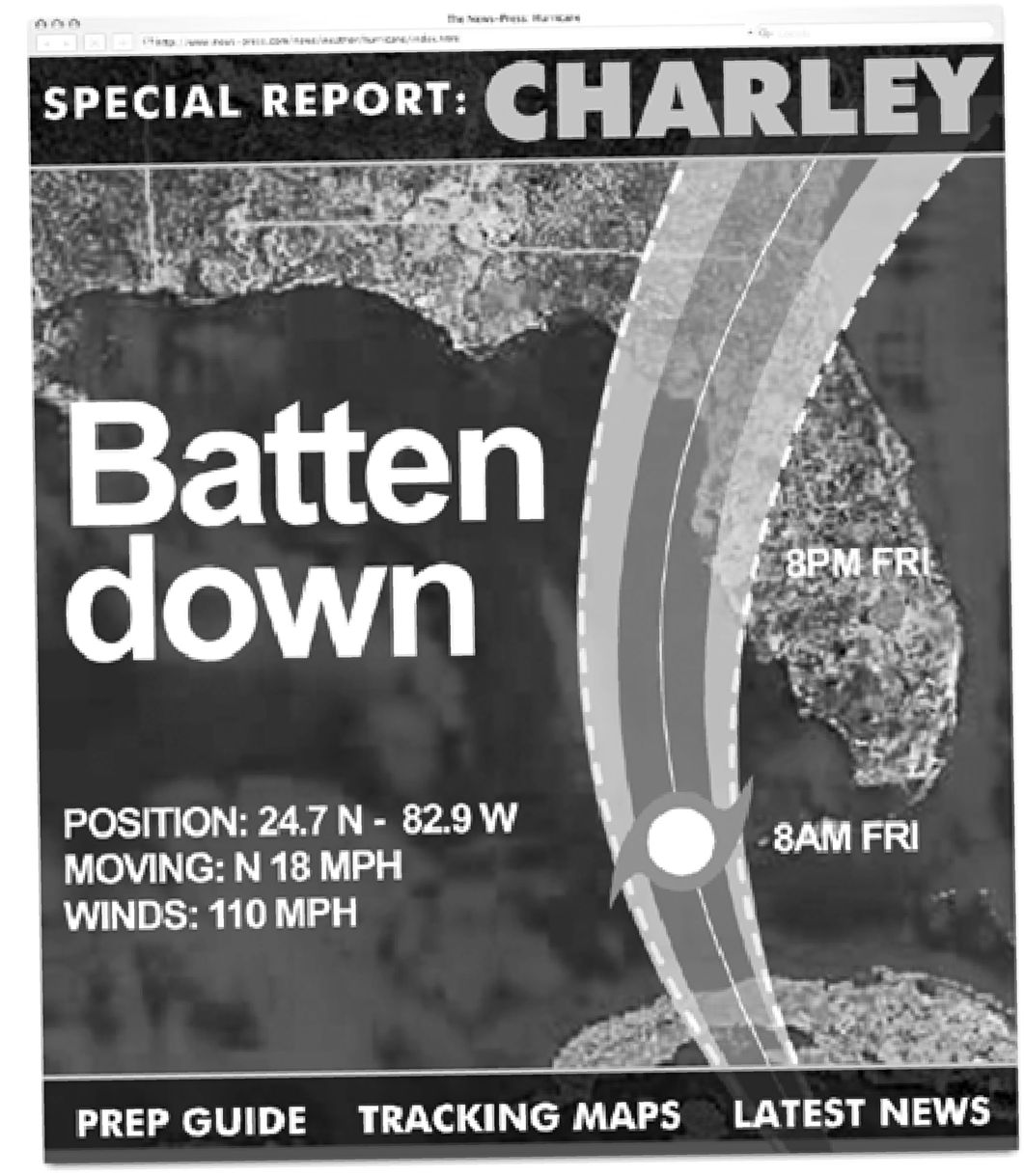
■ Jorge Vergara, 3, walks through the wreckage of his grandparents' mobile home on Sunday, Aug. 15, at the Pink Citrus Trailer Park on Pine Island. He lives nearby in the park, where hurricane winds shredded, flattened and blew over trailers. Jorge's grandparents stayed with family in Naples while waiting for help to find a new home.

Hurricane Charley

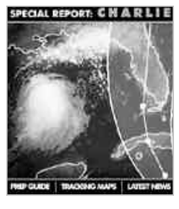
SEVEN DAYS OF STORM COVERAGE — AUGUST 2004

Southwest Florida's worst nightmare, a Category 4 hurricane that suddenly spiraled in magnitude and darted toward our unsuspecting coast, shredded homes and trees and left many residents homeless, hungry and in the dark. This special section recalls the fear, devastation and hope of Southwest Floridians as a 44-year lucky streak ended.





World watches news unfold online





The day Hurricane Charley slammed into Southwest Florida, more than 300,000 people throughout the world turned to news-press.com for minute-by-minute updates.

Reporters spread throughout the region provided uninterrupted updates for 48 hours.

In the following days, the Web site continued to be a source of news for readers worldwide. But it also became a source for a different type of very personal information.

Online forums about specific communities became dialogues between people. A writer in Ohio frantically asked for information about her grandmother. A neighbor of the grandmother checked on her well-being and reassured the granddaughter that all was well.

Readers worldwide could tell each other whose house was still standing, which neighbors needed help. They swapped photos, advice and encouragement.

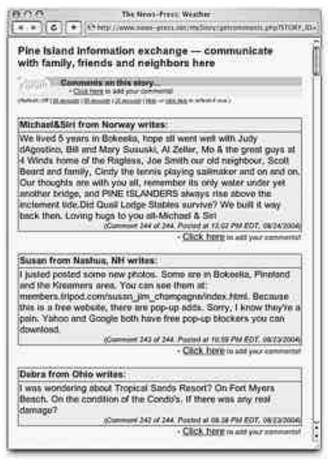
Other innovations created to fill needs that cropped up:

- Breaking news and coping information were both translated into Spanish on the site.
- City officials answered questions from residents in live chats — the only way for person-to-person contact in the early days after the storm.















news-press.com: 24-HOUR COVERAGE OF ALL HURRICANE CHARLEY NEWS AND EVENTS
THE NEWS-PRESS
FRIDAY, AUGUST 13, 2004 | PUBLISHED SINCE 1884 news-press.com FINAL | 50¢

As Hurricane Charley strengthens, SW Floridians

BATTEN DOWN

More than 1 million from Keys to Tampa told to leave as approaching storm nears category 3

Landfall expected early this evening on Fla.'s west coast

BY GRANT BOXLEITNER
gboxleitner@news-press.com

Florida's west coast braced for today's arrival of Hurricane Charley on Thursday as more than 1 million people from Key West to Tampa were told to evacuate their homes ahead of the storm, authorities said.

Forecasters at the National Hurricane Center in Miami predicted Charley will become a Category 3 storm today, packing winds in excess of 110 mph by the time it makes landfall — likely sometime in early evening near the heavily populated Tampa Bay region.

"This is not a storm to be taken lightly," said Pete Winton, spokesman for Lee County government. "We're hoping for the best. There's not much you can do now but stay put."

A hurricane warning and tornado watch stretches along most of Florida's west coast, where a hurricane has not made landfall since Donna in 1960.

Early today, Charley was on the southern Cuba coast, just south of Havana. Forecasters said the storm had top sustained winds of about 105 mph. It was moving north-northwest at about 14 mph.

Up to 1.68 million Floridians are at risk, according to Division of Emergency Management estimates. At least 375,000 vehicles will be involved in the evacuation. The storm, which was 300 miles in diameter late Thursday, could leave behind 5.28 million tons of debris.

This is the type of monster storm state emergency officials have been fearing, one that leaves a path of water- and wind-borne destruction across the peninsula.

"(Charley) could come in anywhere within that hurricane warning area on the west coast," said Martin Nelson, a lead forecaster at the National Hurricane Center.

Even if Charley's center stays in the Gulf as it passes, the storm will still slam Southwest Florida's coastline with a storm

■ See CHARLEY A4



THE ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ A waterspout drops from the clouds over the Gulf of Mexico on Thursday near Sanibel Island as Hurricane Charley approaches. Residents of Sanibel were issued a mandatory evacuation order earlier in the day, with the island drawbridge closing to traffic at 8 p.m.

Charley strengthens





CLINT KRAUSE/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Bonita Beach resident Rafaella Figueroa, 33, watches her 3-month-old daughter, Carolina, while viewing information about Hurricane Charley at Germain Arena in Estero on Thursday. Figueroa and her husband moved here from New York a few months ago and were the first ones to arrive at the arena.

INSIDE

■ Storm surge can be deadly in a hurricane, especially under the right sea and river tide conditions

■ **Coping:** Q&A on local storm issues; what's going on with roads, schools and shelters; riding out the storm

■ **Around Southwest Florida:** Battening down boats in Cape Coral, boarding the cat in Fort Myers, hurricane parties at the Beach

■ **Florida:** Tampa and St. Petersburg, surrounding cities and MacDill Air Force Base also ready for the storm



news-press.com/hurricane

- Storm path projections
- Tracking maps updated every 15 minutes via satellite and radar
- Updated list of open shelters, with addresses and phone numbers
- Key news events and safety information translated into Spanish
- Print out tracking maps
- Latest evacuation orders
- **Interactive graphic:** How hurricanes form, how they destroy and why they are a growing threat to property

Flooding still most dangerous aspect of storm

Storm surge, inland water cause most death, destruction

BY PAMELA SMITH HAYFORD
phayford@news-press.com

The biggest potential for death and damage to property during a hurricane does not lie in the wind.

It's the flooding.

A good part of that is from "surge."

When a hurricane hits land, the wind and pressure push the sea onto the continental shelf and the coastline, what the weather forecasters refer to as the storm surge.

The surge plus the normal tide equals the storm tide.

"We're looking for five or six feet of storm tide if, and only if, it follows the current

■ See STORM SURGE A4

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INSIDE

■ **WEATHER**
High 85 Low 75
Hurricane conditions, heavy rains; complete forecast

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New Jersey governor resigns, cites affair with man

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CHARLEY

■ Continued from A1

surge between 5 and 10 feet, hurricane-force winds in excess of 75 mph and flooding, said meteorologist James Wilson of The Weather Channel.

Southwest Florida could begin to see storms from the outer feeder bands of Charley by sunrise today, with conditions gradually worsening as the storm nears, hurricane forecasters said.

Hurricane-force winds (75 mph and above) extended out 30 miles from Charley's eye Thursday, with tropical storm winds (39 mph and above) stretching 105 miles, forecasters said.

Emergency officials have warned residents to stay indoors and off roads today until Charley passes. Police, fire and EMS vehicles will not travel when sustained winds reach 40 mph, officials said Thursday.

An estimated 130,000 people in Lee, Collier and Charlotte counties were told to evacuate Thursday, according to Southwest Florida emergency management officials. Those evacuation zone includes the islands of Estero, Sanibel, Captiva, Pine and Gasparilla, along with Bonita Beach and all homes west and south of U.S. 41 in Collier County.

Florida Department of Transportation waived tolls Thursday for people traveling east on Alligator Alley. Some area gas stations reported running out of fuel because of high demand.

"People in Captiva and Sanibel who are required to leave, if they go north, they're going to be in trouble," Gov. Jeb Bush said. "The best thing is for them to stay in their own communities."

As its residents fled the island, Sanibel officials set up a temporary city hall Thursday at the Bell Tower Holiday Inn in south Fort Myers, where phones and computer equipment allows them to serve their temporarily displaced population of 6,000.

Many residents had their eyes affixed to televisions and Web site in homes and businesses Thursday to stay informed about what could be the first major hurricane to hit the United States since Bret slammed into a rural area of southeastern Texas in 1999.

The latest projections Thursday keep Charley in the Gulf as it rumbles past Lee County, where a direct hit was considered a possibility earlier Thursday..

But forecasters cautioned hurricane predicting is not an exact science. Even with the best technology available, the computer models still have a margin of error of 80 miles when it comes to projecting where a hurricane will make landfall within 24 hours.

An Air Force surveillance plane spotted a high pressure ridge off Florida's southern coast that allowed Charley to move west a little longer than forecasters originally expected when it was south of Cuba, said Daniel Brown, a meteorologist at the National Hurricane Center. That's what changed the current projected path to a more northern landfall, he said.

"I wouldn't say Fort Myers is out of trouble yet," Brown said. "Any little wobble right or left can make a tremendous difference."

Those who live closest to water that feeds into the Gulf of Mexico — including Charlotte Harbor, saltwater canals and the Caloosahatchee and Peace rivers — will be most vulnerable to localized flooding, NBC-2 meteorologist Robert Van Winkle said.

Traditional flood-prone areas in North Fort Myers and downtown Fort Myers along the riverfront, too, are expected to flood during the storm, city and county officials warned.

Several airlines canceled flights scheduled for today at Southwest Florida International Airport. The airport will remain open as long as no debris is blocking runway areas, said airport spokeswoman Laska Ryan.

Some people in evacuation zones in Lee and Collier counties chose to stay and ride out the storm, according to emergency management officials. Without enough law enforcement personnel to go door to door, people who decide to stay do so at their own risk, officials said.

"Hopefully people have made provisions if that's their decision" to stay, said Collier County spokesman John Torre.

Emergency management officials reported few people staying in available shelters Thursday night in Lee and Collier counties.

— The News-Press Tallahassee Bureau writer Paul Flemming contributed to this report.



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Andrew Cirou, left, of Bonita Jet Ski and Parasail and Ryan Hopkins of Doc's Beach House pile bags of sand in front of the Bonita Beach restaurant in preparation for Hurricane Charley.

STORM SURGE

■ Continued from A1

forecast exactly," said Daniel Noah, a meteorologist with the National Weather Service.

That means if your house sits at four feet above sea level, you could have one or two feet of salt water in your living room.

Even the Caloosahatchee River is expected to rise five feet.

That's only if the storm keeps to the path it was following Thursday, Noah said. One little nudge to the east could greatly increase storm surge.

With the eye of the storm expected to pass 60 miles off Lee County and hurricane force winds only 30 miles off shore, emergency officials warn anything's possible.

But even storm surge is not the deadliest aspect of a hurricane.

Nowadays, storm surge only accounts for 2 percent of hurricane fatalities, Noah said.

"Emergency management is getting good at getting people out of harm's way," Noah said. "The No. 1 killer now is freshwater inland flooding."

Deaths often occur when motorists try to drive over flooded roads.

"What we tell people is 'Turn around, don't drown' if you see water running across the road."

The National Weather Service is expecting four to eight inches of rain on the storm's east side.

STORM SURGE RISK

To find out if your home is at risk of flooding, simply subtract the house foundation's elevation from the storm tide. Most flood insurance papers and site plans have the elevation of the house.

For a more general idea, anyone can go online to the Lee County Property Appraisers office (leepa.org) or the Lee County Emergency Operations Center site (leeeoc.com) and find out what storm surge category they are in.

If you are in a tropical storm area, you could be flooded by storm surge as low as 4.1 feet.

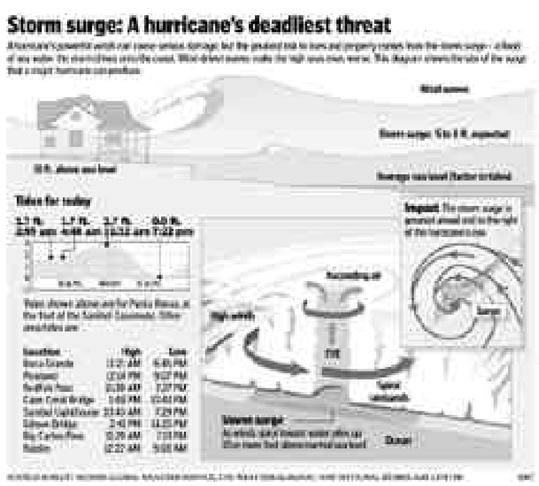
Here are the ranges for hurricanes:

- Category 1: up to 7.4 feet
- Category 2: 7.9 to 12.4 feet
- Category 3: 11.2 to 19.5 feet
- Category 4: 16.5 to 29 feet.



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Tammy Brickley, an employee of Doc's Beach House on Bonita Beach, unloads sandbags along with Andrew Cirou of Bonita Jet Ski and Parasail on Thursday. They are preparing for the onslaught of Hurricane Charley.



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THE NEWS-PRESS
SATURDAY, AUGUST 14, 2004 | PUBLISHED SINCE 1884 | news-press.com | FINAL | 50¢

Hurricane Charley tears through Southwest Florida

DEVASTATED

Category 4 storm leaves several dead in Charlotte County; 145-mph winds ravage region, cause widespread destruction



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Cecil Cavenaugh hugs his grandson, Jacob, 2, while taking a look through the home that Jacob and his sister live in with their grandmother in Suncoast Estates on Friday. Hurricane Charley ripped through the estates causing widespread damage.

More than 468,000 trying to cope without power

BY GRANT BOXLEITNER
gboxleitner@news-press.com

Hurricane Charley dealt a quick but devastating blow to Southwest Florida on Friday, growing into a monster storm before making landfall along the barrier islands of Lee County.

The giant storm cut a path of destruction that leveled homes from Captiva to Punta Gorda and claimed at least three confirmed lives, but the death toll is expected to climb today.

KEY EVENTS

- Several deaths blamed on storm
- Punta Gorda bears brunt; Cape Coral hit hard
- Three Charlotte hospitals relocate hundreds
- Damage could be $15 billion; governor to tour area today

Charlotte County's top emergency management official said early Saturday that Hurricane Charley caused "numerous fatalities."

Wayne Sallade, director of Charlotte's emergency management, did not know the total number of deaths but verified that people died there in the largest storm to hit Florida since Hurricane Andrew in 1992.

"We've got deputies standing by bodies right now," Sallade said. "It's all over, Port Charlotte, Punta Gorda."

Gov. Jeb Bush is scheduled to visit Lee

■ See CHARLEY A6



TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ The remains of the Blossom Florist Shop are scattered across the sidewalk and Marion Avenue in downtown Punta Gorda in the aftermath of Hurricane Charley's devastating path Friday afternoon.

SPECIAL REPORT

- Cape Coral, Pine Island, Charlotte slammed
- Sanibel, Fort Myers Beach residents swamped
- Bonita Springs, Collier County hit early
- Fort Myers, North Fort Myers face damage
- Area residents meet Charley's challenges
- How best to cope with storm's aftermath

news-press.com/hurricane

- Hundreds of photos of devastation from across Southwest Florida
- Continuously updated coverage all day, all night

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CHARLEY

■ Continued from A5

and Charlotte counties today to assess the damage. President Bush has already declared Southwest Florida a federal disaster area, which frees up funds to pay for the massive cleanup.

Early estimates put damage figures at $15 billion, which would make Charley the third costliest disaster in U.S. history behind the Sept. 11 attacks and Hurricane Andrew in 1992, which killed 26 in south Florida.

"We have reports of several homes with roofs off," said Bill Read of the National Hurricane Center in Miami. "It's a mess." Major property damage was reported on Captiva and Useppa islands, Lee County Emergency Management Director John Wilson said. Fifty to 70 percent of the homes incurred major damage, and some may have been destroyed.

"We're not going to allow anyone back on the islands until we find out what's going on. Until those towns or cities give us the all clear we're not going to let anybody out there," Wilson said.

Henry Paul, 46, of Tampa was not sure of the fate of his house on North Captiva, which was among the hardest hit of the barrier islands. County emergency officials said as many as 160 homes may have been destroyed on the 4-mile strip separated from Captiva by a hurricane in the 1920s.

"Hopefully, they got off the island," Paul said. "Hopefully, they all had insurance."

At least 450,000 customers, including most everyone in Lee County, were without power after the storm, and it could take several days for all lines to be repaired, power company representatives from Lee County Electric Cooperative and FPL said.

FPL has 10,000 field and support workers ready to restore power. The utility also has 3,500 employees from other utilities in waiting, and agencies in several Southeastern states may deploy staff to assist, said Kathy Scott, FPL spokesperson.



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ A car sits in a ditch on a side street near Fowler Street in Fort Myers on Friday.

Danny Williams, 25, of 404 Kueka Ave., North Fort Myers, was killed during the storm when he stepped outside for a cigarette and was crushed by a large Banyan tree, Lee County sheriff's officials said.

Outside Lee County, Karen Ryan, 56, of Osprey died in a crash caused by deteriorating conditions on Interstate 75 in south Sarasota County, the Florida Highway Patrol said. And a truck-car collision caused by wind in Orange County killed a young girl.

Officials credited the low death toll to advanced storm forecasting and early evacuations ordered for barrier islands and low-lying homes in Lee, Collier and Charlotte counties.

"It's the diligence of our people who recognized early on that they were in an area that was threatened," said Paul Filla, spokesperson for Lee Public Safety.

Charley was the kind of storm state and local emergency officials feared, a major hurricane slamming into a coastline full of people who didn't experience Hurricane Donna in 1960. That was the last time a storm of this magnitude hit Southwest Florida.

Emergency officials late Friday had only begun to survey the massive damage from the Category 4 storm that later tore through Charlotte Harbor with winds that measured 145 mph, leveling parts of Punta Gorda. Most of Southwest Florida counties experienced tropical storm force winds in excess of 60 mph during the height of the storm.

The roof blew off the Charlotte County sheriff's command center, and Lee County sheriff's officials were trying to help the displaced department locate a temporary site for their operation, Lee County Sheriff Rod Shoap said.

Punta Gorda's historic Presbyterian Church was destroyed along with three of the county's hospitals, Sallade said.

Sallade was speaking by phone from the Lee County Sheriff's Office, which lost one-third of its structure by the storm, temporarily disabling the county's operation.

"The city's historic district is devastated," he said.

On Friday morning, forecasters were predicting Charley to give Lee County a glancing blow, delivering storm surge up to 10 feet but sparing it from the 100-plus mph winds. More computer models put the storm on a track to hit the Tampa Bay region.

But the storm rapidly intensified and began to pick up speed shortly before 2 p.m. That helped Charley to veer farther east than the projected track, said Stacy Stewart, a hurricane specialist at the National Hurricane Center.

"We have no skill in forecasting a 30-mile jog to the east," Stewart said. "Sometimes when storms intensify, they shift around a little bit. It's because it's rotating so fast like a top. It wobbled back to the right and then back to the left."

When the hurricane's speed increased to 20 mph as it made landfall, forecasters said, it potentially spared its path from even more destruction from storm surge had it been going slower. The wall of Gulf water pushed inland by the storm had initial estimates ranging between 6 feet in areas south of the landfall to 15 feet along Charlotte Harbor, the National Hurricane Center said.

Lee County Property Appraiser Ken Wilkinson estimated the storm did nearly $2.3 billion of damage to county structures in the storm's path. Structures in Lee County are valued at $36.7 billion.

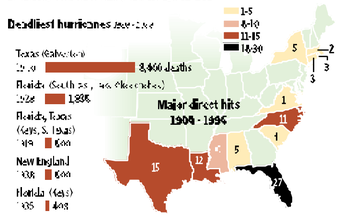
Wilkinson calculated the numbers with a software program designed by his staff after Hurricane Andrew. The results were e-mailed to state officials to begin the steps of securing financial aid from the Federal Emergency Management Administration.

—Staff writer Don Ruane contributed to this report.

Hurricane aftermath

Charley's toll likely to be high

Nearly 7 million people were urged to evacuate the path of Hurricane Charley as it headed toward Florida on Friday. Category 4 Hurricane Charley caused major damage.

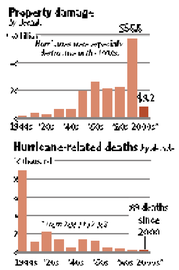


Costliest hurricanes (1900-2003)

	YEAR	COST (Adjusted for inflation to 2003 dollars)	HURRICANE CATEGORY
Andrew	1992	$35.0 billion	5
Hugo	1989	9.7	4
Agnes	1972	8.4	1
Betsy	1965	8.5	3
Camille	1969	7.0	5
Diane	1955	5.5	1
Frederic	1979	5.0	3
Floyd	1999	4.7	2
Unnamed	1926	4.7	3
Fran	1996	3.7	3

Hurricane effects

As more residents live in hurricane-prone areas, extreme tropical weather has caused increasingly costly property damage over the years, but has killed fewer people.



*Through calculations to date figures adjusted to the year 2000.

SOURCE: NATIONAL OCEANIC AND ATMOSPHERIC ADMINISTRATION, NATIONAL HURRICANE CENTER, INSURANCE INFORMATION INSTITUTE

AP GRAPHICS

TIMELINE

WEDNESDAY

■ **7 a.m.** — Lee County Emergency Operations goes into partial activation (Level 2) to monitor Hurricane Charley.

THURSDAY

■ **8 a.m.** — Lee County issues mandatory evacuation of coastal and barrier islands. Bridge tolls suspended. Barrier island schools canceled.
■ **10 a.m.** — Lee County opens seven regular and two special-needs shelters. Citizen hot line activated.
■ **11 a.m.** — Hurricane watch issued for Lee County.
■ **Noon** — Fire departments begin to make sand and sandbags available to residents.
■ **4:20 p.m.** — Florida Department of Transportation lifts tolls at the eastbound toll plaza on Alligator Alley .
■ **5 p.m.** — Lee County under hurricane warning.
■ **6 p.m.** — All 8,000 gallons of gasoline in the underground tanks at the 7-Eleven on Cape Coral Parkway are gone.
■ **7 p.m.** — Sanibel Causeway, Matlacha, Alva, Big Carlos, and State Road 31 drawbridges locked down.
■ **8 p.m.** — LeeTran bus service is stopped.

FRIDAY

■ **2 a.m.** — Hurricane Charley crosses Cuba, eye over western Havana.
■ **5 a.m.** — Hurricane Charley in the Florida Straits with winds near 110 mph.
■ **7 a.m.** — Wind gusts to 124 mph in Cuba, hurricane warning lifted.
■ **7:45 a.m.** — About 450 people are in emergency shelters in Collier County.
■ **8:45 a.m.** — Fort Myers Beach town officials say the island is 90 to 95 percent locked down.
■ **8:50 a.m.** — Sanibel Island issues critical police alert and evacuates all emergency services until further notice.
■ **9 a.m.** — Hurricane Charley moves near the Keys Dry Tortugas with winds near 110 mph. Storm heads north at 18 mph and jogs toward the coast, alarming Southwest Florida emergency officials.
■ **9 a.m.** — Charlotte County residents near Charlotte Harbor, the Myakka River and the Peace River are asked to leave their homes for fear of flooding
■ **10 a.m.** — Cape Coral firefighters run out of sand. Lee County opens eighth regular shelter.
■ **11 a.m.** — Hurricane Charley now about 95 miles south of Fort Myers. Winds still at 110 mph. Storm surge predictions increased to 10 to 13 feet.
■ **1:10 p.m.** — The shelter at Diplomat Middle School nears its capacity of 1,000.
■ **1:15 p.m.** — Winds from Hurricane Charley reach 145 mph and storm is upgraded to a category 4. Storm is about 70 miles from Fort Myers.
■ **1:25 p.m.** — All Cape Coral emergency units ordered to return to their designated stations.
■ **1:30 p.m.** — Golden Gate Fire Rescue stops responding to medical calls.
■ **1:40 p.m.** — Lee County Sheriff's Office pulls all deputies off the road.
■ **2 p.m.** — Charley located about 60 miles from Fort Myers is moving north-northeast at about 20 mph.
■ **2:30 p.m.** — Marco Island residents lose phone service. City goes on battery backup.
■ **3:20 p.m.** — Lee County Emergency Management officials order all emergency vehicles, including law enforcement, fire and emergency medical services off the roads until wind conditions reach a safe level, below 40 mph.
■ **3:45 p.m.** — Charley makes landfall on Captiva with winds of 145 mph.
■ **4 p.m.** — The eye of Hurricane Charley about 20 miles west-northwest of Fort Myers and near Costa Island between Captiva and Boca Grande.
■ **5:15 p.m.** — Eye moves out of Lee County and into Charlotte County.

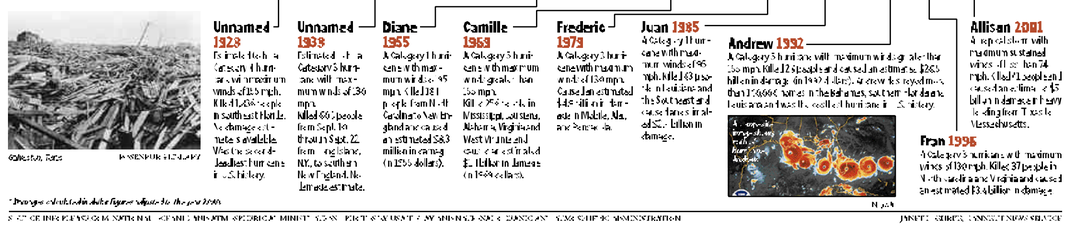


GARTH FRANCIS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Lisa Manahan, 38, of Bonita Springs, stands on her dock on a canal that is connected to the Imperial River. Although the river reached the top of the banks flooding was not a problem after.

History of major U.S. hurricanes

Hurricanes that struck U.S. coastlines during the past century have caused billions of dollars in damage and killed thousands of people.



Galveston, Texas

N.OAA



Fort Myers Beach



Pascagoula, Miss., Gautier Bay

SOURCE: NATIONAL OCEANIC AND ATMOSPHERIC ADMINISTRATION, NATIONAL HURRICANE CENTER, INSURANCE INFORMATION INSTITUTE

JANET GILBERT/NEWS-PRESS GRAPHICS



PHOTOS BY STEPHEN HAYFORD/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Above, a driver maneuvers around roofing material Friday in front of Pro Comp Custom Paint and Collision Repair in Cape Coral. Winds from Hurricane Charley damaged the building's roof.

Despite citywide damage, 'we got lucky'

Debris, downed lines block several roads

The News-Press Staff

Fallen trees and destroyed pool cages blanketed Cape Coral neighborhoods. Roads were blocked with downed power lines, dangling traffic signals and other debris.

All across the city, many homes and businesses had partially torn roofs.

The city was reeling from the storm that brought 90 mph winds and left more than 60,000 people without power late Friday night.

The First National Bank at Santa Barbara Boulevard and Trafalgar Parkway appeared to have no roof left. Fences at Tarpon Point Marina were blown across the street or bent over. The sunset Towers Condo complex also had roof damage.

Cape Coral Hospital lost power and city water, and suffered structural damage just past 4 p.m. Friday.

Part of the roof at the hospital's plant operations building was torn off. It didn't affect patients or staff, said hospital spokeswoman Karen Krieger. A stairwell at the hospital also took on water.

About 6,000 people huddled in two Cape Coral shelters, some standing shoulder to shoulder in hallways to escape the storm.

The city's reverse osmosis plant, which supplies water to residents, was back in operation shortly after the storm passed. There was no boil water notice issued for Cape Coral residents Friday night, but the county may decide to change that if it decides wells could be contaminated, Cape fire chief Bill Van Helden said.

"In Lee County, the barrier islands, Cape Coral and Burnt Store Marina took the brunt of the storm. I was afraid of loss of life," Van Helden said. "It was nothing even close to what we were expecting."

The city had not received any reports of deaths or major injuries due to the storm. But damage will extend into the millions, officials say.

But that may change as residents begin cleaning up their homes and yards.

Homeowners are responsible for removing fallen trees from their property. The city will handle trees that are blocking roadways.

"We got lucky. It could have been much worse," said resident Robert Peters, 23, who lives on Hancock Bridge Parkway. He lost some trees.

A tornado touched down in southwest Cape Coral and damaged several houses in the area of Southwest 6th Avenue near Skyline Boulevard.

Resident Peter Lugo saw the funnel cloud form in the manmade lake behind his house and quickly reported it.

"It was cloud and water, and it was out there swirling. It was really loud, the sound of rushing wind," Lugo said.

The tornado ripped up Lugo's lanai and continued down the line of houses, causing roof and lanai damage, and eventually made its way to the Kimble house.

The Kimbles weren't there, and they said they were glad for that. They were staying in their new duplex, and they'd planned to move out of the Sixth Avenue house Friday. No such luck. Instead, they spent the day loading waterlogged belongings into the trunk of their car and salvaging what they could from their ruined kitchen.

"We have a skylight now," said Sheila Kimble, 52.

About 50 state police were brought in to guide motorists around the littered roads, while city police scoured neighborhoods to handle problems.

Because of the damage, Cape officials imposed a curfew until 7 a.m. today that will resume at 11 p.m., meaning only vehicles providing essential city services could be on the road.

A metal section of roof at Diplomat Middle School was torn off during the storm, according to Mike McNerney, executive assistant for administration with the Lee County School District.

Diplomat was designated as an official emergency shelter by Lee County with a capacity of 1,000, but 1,582 residents flocked to the facility.

Another 5,000 people were packed into a shelter at Cape Coral High School.

Trees blocked portions of Pine Island Road, keeping people from getting on Pine Island.

The road was lined with Charley's fury east toward Cape Coral as the lake near Gerhart Plate's Southwest 10th Avnue. home was "as big as an ocean" thanks to Hurricane Charley.

"I've never seen that water so big," said the Cape Coral resident.

The water was creeping over his seawall but had not yet reached his house as the storm continued to slam the city at about 4:30 p.m.

Half the roof had been ripped off his neighbors' house. Plate thought another neighbor's screened lanai had been dragged into the lake.

"The trees are bare," Plate said. "We have some trees collapsing into the water."

— Charles Runnells: crunnells@news-press, Osvaldo Padilla: opadillo@news-press.com and and Tanya Somaroo: tsamaroo@news-press.com contributed to this report



■ A downed tree rests in the middle of Viscaya Parkway after Charley's rampage through Cape Coral.



■ A Cape Coral police officer directs traffic through the intersection of Santa Barbara Boulevard and Veterans Parkway after Hurricane Charley passed over.



■ At left, traffic lights dangle in the intersection of Country Club Boulevard and Veterans Parkway immediately after the storm.



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Cameron Fancher, 4, hangs on to his mother, Dayna Fancher, while waiting for free food Aug. 16 at the Beach Theatre on Fort Myers Beach.



GARTH FRANCIS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Traffic lights sit on the pavement after being blown down Aug. 13 at the intersection of Bonita Beach Road and U.S. 41 in Bonita Springs.



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Gerard Campanella, owner of the Bicycle Center on U.S. 41 in Port Charlotte, waits for wood to cover the windows of his business Aug. 15. He said the reality of the hurricane was finally starting to sink in.



STEPHEN HAYFORD/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Lourdes Valdez, 26, feeds 19-day-old daughter Leslie Cruz while sitting with 3-year-old daughter Cecilia Cruz on their mattresses at a temporary shelter Aug. 21. Valdez, her husband and three children have been staying at Our Lady of the Miraculous Medal Catholic Church on Pine Island since the day after Hurricane Charley hit Southwest Florida. The family is unsure of where they will go next, having lost a portion of their mobile home in Pink Citrus Trailer Park.

BEFORE



AFTER



PHOTOS BY TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ The Blossom Florist Shop in Punta Gorda the day before Hurricane Charley.

■ The remains of the Blossom Florist Shop scattered across the sidewalk and street after Hurricane Charley.



GARTH FRANCIS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Two men run through the driving rain Aug. 13 on their way into Germain Arena, which was set up as a hurricane shelter by the American Red Cross. Umbrellas did not hold up to the gusts reaching 80 mile per hour.



PHOTOS BY MARC BEAUDIN/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Emergency vehicles pass down Estero Boulevard on Fort Myers Beach. The main road on the beach is covered with sand and debris.

House fire among soaked island's woes

The News-Press staff

At least one Fort Myers Beach home was destroyed by fire when flames broke out during Friday's storm while Beach fire officials were still evacuated.

Lee County Sheriff's Office deputies noticed smoke coming from a home at 275 Pearl St. before 6 p.m. By the time Fort Myers Beach Fire District trucks arrived, the home was fully involved and the fire had spread to a neighboring home, fire spokesman Bill Lees said.

"We were in the process of moving back to the island" when the call came, Lees said. He was unsure how long it took firefighters to arrive but said it was an "extended period of time."

Fire officials still were on the scene late Friday night, and Lees was unsure how extensive the damage on the second house is or the home's street number.

Lees has not heard of any injuries related to the fire but said he could not confirm that no one was hurt.

A manatee washed ashore with Hurricane Charley on Fort Myers Beach Friday afternoon.

The manatee came ashore from Estero Bay onto Delmar Avenue and made its way to Estero Boulevard.

That's where about two dozen people found the manatee, tied it to a pickup truck and pulled it down the sand-covered boulevard to a boat ramp nearby. The manatee lumbered away into the bay.

Several front-loaders were clearing piles of sand, downed trees and other debris from Estero Boulevard on Fort Myers Beach, hoping to prepare the island so residents and business owners can reenter as soon as possible, said Lees.

Entry to the Beach remains limited access. Only those with proof of residency are being allowed back on, but not even all residents are being given access, Lees, said.

"We're working as fast as we can," he said.

When all residents will be allowed to return remained uncertain late Friday night, he said.

Michael Santaguiva, 53, rode out the storm with a friend at his place in Gullwing Resort at the south end of the island.

They stood out on their lanai for a portion of the storm but said "it would blow you back in."

"It was crazy watching the gulls fly. They were flopping their wings and trying to fly as hard as they could but they kept going backward."

While at one point Estero Boulevard was under about 2 feet of water, it appeared to slow by the end of the day.

Driving along the boulevard was like going down a country dirt road.

There was standing water on both sides of the street but the streets were passable.

Power lines are down and the smell of propane was prevalent.

Trees were down across the island. Trash cans were scattered across the streets. Even a refrigerator washed into the roadway.

SAN CARLOS ISLAND: DEBRIS, FLOODING

Bob Byers, 82, of Nancy Lane on San Carlos Island said he decided to stay in his mobile home throughout the storm. "I sat here and watched the whole thing.

"I watched the roof of the house across the canal from me come off," he said, pointing to the mangled remains of the roof in question.

The next thing that happened, he said, was a large piece of awning hit the side of his house, and then went into his back yard when the wind changed.

Unlike many of his neighbors, he did not have any water in his house and attributed that to the fact that in 1980, when he installed his house, he had it elevated 9 feet above the mean high tide level instead of the legally required 7 feet. "If it had been 8 feet, we'd have gotten water inside," he said.

Another San Carlos Island resident, Charlie Hameetman, said that he did not have any water in his house, "but we did go swimming in the back yard earlier." He stayed to protect the family pets, including a dog and a pot-bellied pig, he said.

Beach Seafood, a seafood retail operation, had a huge chunk of its roof hanging down over the front of the building. Elsewhere on the island's streets, pieces of manufactured homes, lawn furniture and downed trees were common, and power still had not been restored as night fell.

Earlier in the day, a sailboat broke free from its mooring in Hurricane Bay.

The sailboat broke loose and was pushed into Hurricane Pass bridge by intense winds. Large pieces of the boat actually fell off and went flying through the air.

— Reported by Alison Keppner: akepner@news-press.com, Dick Hogan: dhogan@news-press.com and Sarah Lundy: dslundy@news-press.com



■ A traffic light on Estero Boulevard dangles from a downed line on Fort Myers Beach.



■ Madera Road on Fort Myers Beach is washed away by Hurricane Charley.



■ Hurricane-force winds blow trees and debris on Fort Myers Beach.



TODD STUBING/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Pine Island firefighter Shawn Brant, right, with landscaper Jeff Cottrell, of Cape Coral, cuts apart a tree near downed power lines that were blocking Pine Island Road at Southwest 20th Avenue after Hurricane Charley passed through. The firefighters could not get back to Pine Island because of all the downed trees until they cut paths through them.

"What it took Punta Gorda 200 years to build, it took out in a hurry."

■ **Charles Rinehart,**
Police chief and head of emergency operations for the city of Punta Gorda



PHOTOS BY TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Floodwaters from Hurricane Charley inundated sections of West Olympia Street in Punta Gorda.

Locals survey the swath from Charley

Pine Island: Bridge, power poles smashed

BY BETSY CLAYTON
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Sheared of letters and parts of its facade, Pine Island's only supermarket sported a new name Friday night courtesy of Hurricane Charley: WINN DI.

Residents trickled back to the island, darting around fallen power poles and pine trees that blocked roads through much of northern Cape Coral and Pine Island.

What they found: debris swept into streets from what looked like a relatively minor storm surge; homes and storefronts sheared of sidings, shingles or roofs; and 50- and 60-foot trees uprooted or snapped midtrunk.

In Matlacha, where part of the Bridgewater Inn's roof was peeled off, and Michaela's Snook Inn appeared to have lost its bayfront dining deck.

Returning residents and those who rode out the storm stood staring at their homes and yards, shaking their heads.

Some started picking up tree limbs and aluminum siding sheets. Many talked on cell phones.

A communications tower still stood near Pine Island Center — though bent over near its peak. Pine Island Fire Department Station No. 1 lost a major section of its roof, and shelters over gas pumps at the Circle K and Citgo station were blown over.

In Phillips Park, fencing around the community swimming pool and tennis courts was strewn across the grass.

But the nearby Dairy Queen looked unscathed.

Street signs were toppled in every neighborhood, but residents gathered in the roads to compare damage and check on neighbors and friends.

The water flooded the road as Charley passed over the island.

There wasn't any standing water on the road before the Matlacha Bridge, but telephone poles on the other side of the bridge were bent.

Power lines were down and in the road on the second little bridge to Matlacha.



■ An Interstate 75 sign was uprooted and tossed to the ground near Tuckers Grade Road in Punta Gorda during Hurricane Charley's rampage through the area.

Punta Gorda chief: 'We're devastated'

BY OSVALDO PADILLA
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Hurricane Charley ravaged Punta Gorda on Friday. Businesses were ripped open, walls were torn from homes and tossed upside down by powerful winds.

"What it took Punta Gorda 200 years to build, it took out in a hurry," said Charles Rinehart, police chief and head of emergency operations. "We're devastated."

Power lines and trees, lumber and nails were scattered along Punta Gorda Isles and downtown Punta Gorda.

Police spent the evening turning away cars on U.S. 41, trying to ease traffic in the hardest-hit areas.

Navigating the roadways was difficult for motorists who dodged debris as they tried reaching their homes and businesses.

Police spent Friday night patrolling streets to prevent looting.

Tractors were expected to return this morning to ravaged areas to pull trees and rubble off the roads. Federal and state officials from various agencies were expected to arrive to help with the cleanup.

With windows broken on the south side of the three-story building, the Professional Center on West Marion Street looked as if a bomb had shattered the structure.

The damage also brought out the curious and adrenaline junkies.

"There's a lot of bad stuff," said David Wotitzky, 18, who surveyed damage from his truck.

Meanwhile, a team of freelance storm chasers bolted their meteorological equipment onto the top of a Ford Focus and videotaped Charley's wrath.

"We clocked 150 mile-per-hour gusts. It was very, very strong," said Christopher Collura with Weathervine.com.

Residents could do little but sit and wait for the eye of the storm to sweep through the area.

Many were stunned by the storm's intensity and speed.

"It was like a camera flash, but it lasted 10 minutes," said Pamela Thordar.

"It was really, really scary," she said.



PHOTOS BY AMANDA INSCORE/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Sgt. Robert Forrest of the Lee County Sheriff's Office handcuffs Sanibel resident Christie Holahan after she tried to walk past a police barricade on Summerlin Road on the way to the Sanibel Causeway. Holahan eventually was released. Police said they will assess the condition of the bridge and then allow residents to cross if it is safe.



■ Pam Swails prepares a kite Friday for a fellow kiteboarder who wanted to take advantage of higher winds near the Sanibel Causeway.



■ Arthur Celino of Marshfield, Mass., enjoys the cool wind Friday evening on Bunche Beach in south Fort Myers. The parking lot of the beach was partially washed away by the storm surge, and John Morris Road leading up to the beach was mostly underwater.

Causeway closed until it can be inspected

BY ANNE MITCHELL
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The Sanibel Causeway survived the storm, but its condition is unknown. Lee County sheriff's deputies were turning back drivers near Shell Point Boulevard about a mile before the toll booth.

Lee County sheriff's deputy Ramon Serrano said, "There were many power lines down on the approach to the causeway. The toll booth is leaning over a little and a construction trailer was in the middle of the road."

These trailers were put in place by Lee County for the causeway construction project. The road to Sanibel was littered with downed trees, billboards and severed power lines. No traffic lights were working.

Off the island, the canopy of the new UGas filling station at Bruno's Food Store on McGregor Boulevard was toppled.

As darkness fell, deputies at the roadblock said emergency personnel decided to check the safety of the bridge in the daylight today and would not be allowing anyone back on the island Friday night.



■ Nick Frantz, right, helps his father load sandbags at Bunche Beach for use at their home in the Iona/McGregor area in preparation for Hurricane Charley on Friday.

Christie Holahan was so anxious to get back home to Sanibel she ignored a police roadblock and tried to walk across.

Sheriff's Sgt. Robert Forrest handcuffed Holahan and put her in the back of the squad car. Her husband, Mike Holahan, pleaded with the deputy to let her go.

"She's depressed, she just wants to go home," he said.

After a spell, Forrest removed the woman's handcuffs and told her she could go free.

Mike Holahan said, "Are they going to lock somebody up for trying to go home?"

J.R. Island, manager of Sanibel Marina, was one of those turned back trying to get to Sanibel Island. He didn't know how badly the storm had affected Sanibel, but he said he had a lot of boats at the marina to check on.

Deputies told him to try back later, but soon said the bridge would be closed Friday night.

Jim Barry, 70, decided to tough it out on Sanibel. He had come down last week from Boston to "spiff up the house," which he is selling. Instead, he ended up watching his neighbor's pool screen collapse and seeing some of the shingles fly off his own roof.

Barry said that Periwinkle Way was blocked near Dixie Beach Boulevard by fallen trees and said a tree had fallen on a house on the street.

"It was awful," he said.

It was worse than he thought.

"I have ridden out a few nor'easters in Boston but this was tougher."

He sat on his lanai for a while and watched the storm.

"It was a spooky feeling, the power was unbelievable."



PHOTOS BY CLINT KRAUSE/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Lee County sheriff's deputies direct traffic Friday evening at the intersection of U.S. 41 and Bonita Beach Road after Hurricane Charley passed.

Surprising Charley stuns residents

The News-Press Staff

Clad in camouflage fatigues, Sgt. Derek Creamer, of the Lee County Sheriff's Office, stood in a driving rain trying to direct traffic around 13 stoplights that were in the middle of the road.

"I'm trying to keep people from running over the lights, and trying to keep people from going to the beach," he said.

"People are out just taking a drive (to see) what the beach looks like."

Capt. Richard Younger, heading the sheriff's command post at First Presbyterian Church of Bonita Springs, was shocked at at the amount of traffic on the road less than an hour after Charley's winds subsided.

"Stay home," Younger said.

Younger had witnessed the storm's surge as it came on to Bonita Beach.

"It was unreal," he said. "The Gulf was calm ... like being out in my boat. Twenty minutes later five to 8-footers were coming up on the beach."

BONITA OFFICIALS ASSESS DAMAGE

Bonita Springs Mayor Jay Arend said he and City Manager Gary Price were assessing the damage on Bonita Beach.

The two had seen sections of roof, aluminum siding and sections of a stairway strewn across the road on their first tour.

"There's multimillions worth of damage just on Hickory Boulevard," Arend said.

The water was 4 feet deep across Hickory Boulevard at some points, Arend said.

Elsewhere in Bonita Springs, part of the Bonita Bay Pavilion came down, but the rest of the city seemed to survive pretty well, the mayor said.

DEPUTIES BLOCK ANXIOUS RESIDENTS

At the corner of Bonita Beach Road and Imperial Shores, about 40 residents, some of them angry, tried to force sheriff's deputies to let them go on to Bonita Beach.

"We asked them to check our homes," said Tanya Batchelor, who lives near Public Beach Access No. 5.

The deputies refused to let the residents pass because of the amount of debris and dangerous conditions.

Arend said shattered glass from homes and and "millions of coconuts" were among the debris.

CLOSER LOOK REVEALS STORM DAMAGE

On first glance, Little Hickory Island appeared to have escaped most of Charley's wrath.

But a closer look at the the beach showed how fierce Charley really was.

Beach sand was blown and washed across Hickory Boulevard and piled into mounds on driveways.

At one beachfront home, stairs were ripped from the end of a boardwalk and embedded into a nearby sand dune.

Pieces of a beach boardwalk were picked up and strewn like brown sticks of gum. In another area, posts were uprooted and tossed about like matchsticks.

HOMEOWNERS WORRY ABOUT TURTLE NESTS

Jon and Rebecca Loft rode out the storm in their three-story beachfront home.

"They made us build a fortress," Rebecca Loft said.

And the fortress stood. The pool cage didn't.

The three-story pool cage looked like a bees' honeycomb. Part of it fell into the pool, some stood against the house and some fell into the hot tub.

"It looks like a giant went through with a sledge hammer, doesn't it," John Loft said. "I didn't know whether to cry or drink wine," Rebecca Loft said.

She also worried about two turtle nests on the beach at the back of the house.

She tried to save some of the eggs, but others were covered with more than a foot of new sand from the storm surge.

The surge was "unbelievable," Loft said. "It was like a roaring train."

EVERGLADES CITY GOES UNHARMED

Everglades City, which was hit hard during Hurricane Andrew, escaped Charley unscathed.

"It didn't even blow the oranges off my tree," Mayor Sammy Hamilton said. "We're lucky; it's beautiful here."

Hamilton said that despite evacuation orders about 75 percent of the people stayed in Everglades City during the storm.

RESIDENTS ALLOWED BACK ON MARCO ISLAND

Marco Island City Manager Bill Moss said residents there could return Friday night, but he urged them to use extreme caution because power lines were down and debris was in the streets.

MAN, DAUGHTER CAUGHT IN VEHICLE

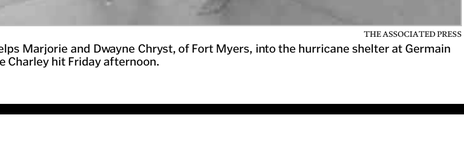
A man, his teenage daughter and their pet dog escaped injury when a tree and a power line fell on their car while they were sightseeing at Naples Beach during the storm.

They were in their car at the beach at the end of Fifth Avenue South when high winds blew the tree over, said Victor Morales, assistant to the city manager.

The tree dragged the power line with it and both fell on top of the car. A crew from Florida Power & Light was called in to cut off the electricity to the line so that rescue crew could get them out of the car, Morales said.

The unidentified man was treated for minor injuries at Naples Community Hospital, his daughter and dog were uninjured.

— Reported by Mary Wozniak: mwozniak@news-press.com; Denes Husty: dhusty@news-press.com; Ryan Hiraki: rhiraki@news-press.com



THE ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Eduardo Castillo, right, helps Marjorie and Dwayne Chryst, of Fort Myers, into the hurricane shelter at Germain Arena in Estero as Hurricane Charley hit Friday afternoon.



CLINT KRAUSE/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ An uprooted tree impacts two homes east of Hickory Boulevard on Bonita Beach after Hurricane Charley on Friday evening.

"It's gone. Everything I own is gone."

■ **Helen Wilson,**
a 58-year-old grandmother of two living in North Fort Myers



PHOTOS BY ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Fallen trees crush a mobile home in Mere's Mobile Home Park from the effects of Hurricane Charley.

Wind, floodwaters ravage mobile homes

BY JEFF CULL
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When Helen Wilson returned to her mobile home in North Fort Myers after waiting out Hurricane Charley at relatives, she couldn't believe the damage.

"It's gone," said the 58-year-old grandmother of two. "Everything I own is gone."

Winds peeled the roof off her McDaniel Road mobile home exposing the living room and one bedroom to the rains.

"All we saved out of the living room was the pictures," said Wilson's son, David Bishop. "The TV is gone; everything was destroyed."

As Wilson cuddled her 2-year-old grandson, Jacob, she wondered out loud what she will do.

"The wind just took it," she said and added she will stay with relatives Friday night and contact the Red Cross today.

North Fort Myers was littered with downed power lines, felled trees, severed branches, roof tiles and metal siding. Electric power was out in most of the community.

Inland flooding was generally isolated to some poor draining roads and yards. There were reports of homes being flooded near Stillwater Court, north of Hancock Bridge Parkway.

Storm surge, however, caused flooding at some businesses near the Caloosahatchee River.

Floodwaters crept about 200 feet into the parking lot of Prosperity Pointe Marina near the Edison Bridge on Business U.S. 41. One building on the site had at least 2 feet of water, said Keith Ellis, who wadded out to check his boat that was moored at the marina.

"We're finding quite a bit of damage," said Capt. Steve Goff, of the North Fort Myers Fire Department. Fire crews were out at 6 p.m. surveying damage.

And a number of mobile homes couldn't weather the fierce winds.

James Gott huddled with his wife and two children in their Hart Road mobile home and watched Charley uproot a pair of oak trees in his yard. Seconds later, the roof was gone.

"It sounded like opening a can of soda," he said. "It was just woosh."

Gott, like so many other Southwest Floridians, was surprised by the storm's fury.

"If I'd have know it was going to be this bad, we never would have stayed."

High winds caused most of the damage in North Fort Myers.

An almost 80-foot oak tree was uprooted on Business U.S. 41 at the height of the storm.

"It sounded like a bomb," said Kathy Olsen, describing the sound when the tree fell near her motel room.

Olsen just moved to the area from New York and is staying at the Welcome-In Motel until her home is ready. "I'm in room 13, it's the 13th (of August), and now this. Welcome to Fort Myers," she said.



■ Amber Cavenaugh, 7, hangs onto her grandfather Cecil Cavenaugh on Friday after losing her home in Suncoast Estates to Hurricane Charley. The storm swept through Southwest Florida causing significant damage.



TODD STUBING/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ The U.S. Post Office in downtown Fort Myers suffered major damage to its roof from Hurricane Charley.

Downtown not spared by hurricane

BY MARK MARYMONT
Special to The News-Press

Hurricane Charley wasn't in Fort Myers very long, but he left his mark.

By early evening Friday, brief but vigorous squalls still were passing over the downtown area's water-logged streets, including Palm Beach Boulevard, near Terry Park and on the west side of Billy's Creek.

The Fort Myers Police Department was without power at midevening. Spokeswoman Kara Winton said the headquarters were dark, "and we are concerned the public is wondering why we don't answer our phones. We have an emergency generator crew on the scene, and we hope to be back up soon."

While other downtown streets were open, they were hardly safe. Debris, especially tree limbs, clogged some side streets. Numerous bent and snapped signs were also mute testimony to the power of Charley.

Despite the intermittently heavy rain, there were people downtown. One solitary pedestrian braved the storm in white rubber boots and a bright yellow rain slicker. Meanwhile, Greg Donovan, who owns property throughout the county, was cleaning up in front of an office he owns that houses a law firm on Main Street.

"It's just a lot of glass all over the place," Donovan said. "I guess it was just the wind. You can see it all over town."

Justin Alderman was making a permanent record of the damage. He had about 45 minutes of video and was still taping.

"I just want to make a record of the storm and all the damage," said Alderman, who lives in the Earnhardt Building. "It's just kind of a souvenir of the whole thing."

Edward Dees didn't make a tape, but he saw the storm up close and personal.

"Another guy and I watched the storm from the Municipal Parking Garage," said Dees, riding a bike near the Harborside Event Center. "We got pretty wet but a building across the street blocked a lot of the rain. The wind just kept building and it was kind of scary, especially in the middle of the storm. I thought it would never end."

Dees, who has never experienced a hurricane before, said he was ready to move back north.

Other folks were offered the chance to ride out the storm, even if it meant cold cuts and sleeping on the floor.

"We have about 70 men and some families who are clients," said Gaynell Thacker, of the Fort Myers Rescue Mission. "They live here all the time, then we have a few other people, including three single men. Most everybody is holed up now and we are just waiting out the storm."

Thacker said clients and guests alike were trying to help each other, "because it's just one of those times when you try and make it through everything. We give them three meals a day, but today we are going cold, in case we lose power."

Asked if they still had room at the shelter on Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., Boulevard, Thacker said at midafternoon they were pretty full, "but we would always try and bring them in in an emergency like this. They might have to sleep on the floor, but we would get them in."

The Salvation Army Red Shield Lodge was full and on the move.

"We have 98 clients and we evacuated them all to Dunbar High School early this afternoon," said Patti Rigby, director of medical services for the Salvation Army. "We just aren't safe enough here for this kind of storm. So we took everybody to Dunbar. We hope to get them back here no later than Saturday morning."

While the clients were evacuated, Rigby said 16 staffers were staying at the center, "because we have lots of pets here and you can't take them to the other shelters. So we'll just ride it out here."

Although downtown Fort Myers was pretty much deserted by early afternoon, there were still a couple of homeless men on the street. Winton said the police would try to help them in a situation like Hurricane Charley.

"We would approach them and offer them a ride and ask if they wanted to go to a shelter," Winton said. "It would be in our policy and our nature to do that."



TODD STUBING/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ "I just wanted to be a part of it," says Barry Reyes, 28, a resident of downtown Fort Myers, as he walks toward the Caloosahatchee River near the Harborside Event Center.

Evening drive reveals surreal, altered city

Note: The News-Press reporter Chris Wadsworth drove through areas of Fort Myers on Friday evening, taking a co-worker to check on her damaged home. Here is what he observed.

BY CHRIS WADSWORTH
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As we left The News-Press, we had to dodge debris in the parking lot. Large pieces from our facility's roof were everywhere. Large palm fronds and tree branches littered the streets of downtown Fort Myers. Traffic lights were out, some hanging low to the ground on broken cables. Drivers were showing uncharacteristic courtesy as everyone drove slowly and patiently.

The damage really became noticeable as we turned onto McGregor Boulevard. We saw many uprooted trees at a church just north of the Edison-Ford Estates. Church members were already there, surveying the damage.

The Edison-Ford Estates looked devastated. While the homes and buildings themselves *appeared* intact, at least a dozen of the large trees that graced the historic property were downed. This is just what we could see from the road. I fear there was more damage elsewhere on the property.

As we continued south on McGregor, we noticed at least six of the famous McGregor palm trees toppled. One had crashed through the white picket fence that surrounds the Edison property. Others had fallen across roads, or just appeared shredded and naked.

We saw many roads underwater, large rust-colored pools that stretched across intersections into yards.

In the twilight, neighbors were out talking, walking and exploring this new post-hurricane world. As the sun set, they started disappearing into their warm, powerless homes.

By the time we headed back to The News-Press, the sun had completely set and night was here. There were few lights anywhere, except in some gas stations and stores along U.S. 41 that clearly had batteries or generators working overtime.

Just between the Fort Myers Country Club golf course and downtown, we noticed many store signs shattered and blown out, including those at a car wash, a motel and a Circle-K convenience store.

Fort Myers police cars were everywhere and their red-and-blue lights up and down 41 gave the otherwise dark street the appearance of an airport runway.

It was a surreal experience, driving the same roads I drive every day, but seeing them suddenly, dramatically altered. These were my observations, driving through Fort Myers the night Charley came to town.



TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Downtown Fort Myers is seen from the Fort Myers Yacht Basin late Friday afternoon as Hurricane Charley first struck.

400 patients moved from Charlotte

BY PAUL FLEMMING
The News-Press Tallahassee Bureau

andPETE STELLA
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About 400 patients will be moved to other area hospitals, including Lehigh Regional Medical Center, from three Charlotte County hospitals damaged by Hurricane Charley.

Charlotte Regional Medical Center in Punta Gorda, Bon Secours-St. Joseph's Hospital in Port Charlotte and Fawcett Memorial Hospital in Port Charlotte were damaged in the storm. All need to move patients, said Alan Levine, secretary of Florida's Agency for Health Care Administration.

Ambulances from around the state will be brought in beginning today to move the patients.

Levine said he had reports that "a good portion" of the roof at Charlotte Regional had come off and the hospital was without primary or backup power. Six patients on ventilators at Fawcett Memorial Hospital required specialized transport to be moved.

Hospitals in Lee County also sustained some damage.

Windows designed to let smoke out let in a lot of rain at HealthPark Medical Center.

High winds Friday blew open "operable windows" in the hospital and about 70 patients had to be moved.

"We moved the patients out of the patient rooms to fix the windows," said Dave Kistel, vice president of facility planning and supply services at HealthPark. "We got them all moved out of harms way."

The HealthPark ER was open Friday evening, "and we have been accepting patients"Kistel said. "But we have been working with the EMS people and other hospitals for our ER patients."

HealthPark also sustained damage to an atrium skylight and a number of trees and lights were down.

The storm prevented Emergency Medical Services from responding to calls seeking help until around 7 p.m.

Cape Coral Hospital had some roof damage at the plant operations building and lost power and water. The building, at the back of the hospital, also reported some window and water damage as well as several trees knocked over.

Southwest Florida Regional Medical Center and Gulf Coast Hospital both sustained structural damage. Doors were blown from their hinges and roof problems were reported at both buildings.



AMANDA INSCORE/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ High winds toppled the roof covering the gas pumps at Bruno's Food Store on McGregor Boulevard in south Fort Myers during Hurricane Charley on Friday.

Samaritans lend a hand during crisis

BY SAM COOK
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The hurricane hero at the Caldwell home on Northeast 18th Terrace in Cape Coral didn't move an inch.

It didn't toss one sandbag.

Or nail a single shutter.

Terry Caldwell just popped the hood of a 2004 F150 XL Ford truck and provided an electrical source for the family during Hurricane Charley.

"It's not going to run the whole house, but it will give us the bare necessities," said Caldwell, 52.

Caldwell and his son, Matthew, 15, a Cape Coral High School sophomore, hooked up a power inverter to the truck battery at about 2 p.m.

The inverter converts direct current to alternating current.

"It'll run the TV and the refrigerator," Matthew Caldwell said. "We've used it before when we had power out to watch DVDs."

The Caldwells, who moved to Cape Coral last year from North Carolina, put up galvanized, corrugated steel shutters and brought everything in their yard that moved inside.

"We've got a full tank of gas," Terry Caldwell said. "If we run out, we have two more cars in the garage that will work."

The Caldwells were ready to weather the storm, but dad cautioned son to remind him about one thing when it was over.

"Don't forget to tell me I got this truck all plugged up," Terry Caldwell said. "I'll be liable to pull the house away with it."



TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Todd Puckett, captain of the M.V. Mouse, a Navy boat from Tampa, walks along the pier near his boat at the Fort Myers Yacht basin late Friday afternoon as Hurricane Charley made its way up the Caloosahatchee River. Puckett said he had moved the boat to Fort Myers from Tampa to take refuge from the projected path of the storm.

SISTER'S SAFE HAVEN

Tim and Lori Burton work for a flood and restoration company, so they know the devastation a hurricane can bring.

They live a half-mile from the Caloosahatchee River on West Gardenia Circle in North Fort Myers.

The Burtons didn't hesitate to take an offer from Lori's sister, Sandy Yorty, to move to higher ground on Northeast 19th Street in Cape Coral about 1:30 p.m.

"We'd still be in North Fort Myers if it wasn't for the rising water," said Tim Burton, who works for Nu-Image Claims. "We prepped the house the best we could. I'm not worried about the windows, they're hurricane proof.

"I lifted everything off the floor and put them high enough for the flood not to reach them, but not too high for roof damage to hurt them."

Sandy Yorty said the offer to her sister was a no-brainer.

"We just knew the water was getting higher over there and Cape Coral is a better area for a flood zone," she said.

Bob and Sandy Yorty prepare for emergencies. Three years ago, they earned certification for the Community Emergency Rescue Team.

"If this hurricane would have waited a week, I'd have been certified to do CPR," said their daughter, Kim Yorty, 17, who is working on a nursing degree at High Tech Center-North.

WATER WORRIES

If you needed sand in North Fort Myers, Dennis Blake was the man to see.

"We just put a septic tank in our yard on Cabana Avenue, so we've got extra sand for the neighbors," said Blake, 43.

Blake said he had been helping friends set sandbags for two days in the neighborhood, a quarter mile north of the Caloosahatchee River.

"The last time we got flooded, the water was up this high," said Blake, positioning his hand four feet above the street. "We were out here in boats and canoes."

Noelle Denucci of Fourth Way was relieved Blake came to their aid.

"I was panicking," Denucci said. "I had seven inches of rain in my home the last time this happened. Dennis helped me out with 15 sandbags."

Nicole Myers, who also lives on Cabana Avenue, wasn't coping well with the icky weather.

"I wish I was back in Michigan," said Myers, 18. "I'd rather be in a snowstorm than this stuff.

"The only good thing about today is I made $40 in tips at Bob Evans restaurant in just an hour and a half."

NEIGHBORLY AID

Three families on Brooks Court in North Fort Myers circled the sandbags.

Shawn Wittwer said he saw neighbor Andy Sievert "sweating his butt off," so Wittwer and sons Quinton, 12, and Dillon, 11, picked up 27 sandbags at the fire station and helped out.

"Both can handle a sandbag real well," said Shawn Wittwer about his sons. "We work it out in trade. Andy gives me flowers and pepper plants."

Sievert, 60, said he stacked 45 sandbags around his house.

"My wife Lori said maybe we should stack them two layers high," said Sievert, who vetoed the suggestion. "I'm lucky I got such good friends to pitch in."

Shawn Wittwer, 33, and Sievert said about 12:30 p.m. the only thing left to do was enclose the pool area for Ernest Wittwer, Shawn's father.

"We just need to put a few sandbags against the door, so the water will drain into the pool," said Ernest Wittwer, 63.

Sievert, who has lived on Brooks Court for 32 years, said he tied about 100 plants to a chain-link fence in his back yard.

"If you see my chain-link fence going with the wind, it's going to take my plants with it," he said, looking up at the sky.

news-press.com: 24-HOUR COVERAGE OF ALL HURRICANE CHARLEY NEWS AND EVENTS

THE NEWS-PRESS

SUNDAY, AUGUST 15, 2004

SPECIAL REPORT
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CLINT KRAUSE/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ An aerial photo shows the destruction by Hurricane Charley at Pineland Marina on Pine Island on Saturday.

Southwest Florida residents face reality of Charley's wrath

DARK DAY

At least 13 dead; early estimates put statewide damage at $15 billion

From staff and wire reports

Jeb Bush said it all: "Our worst fears have come true."

As dawn broke Saturday, the misery, destruction and death that Hurricane Charley rained on Southwest Florida became a nightmarish reality.

At least 13 dead across the state, including four in Charlotte County and one man in Lee.

Hundreds of people missing. Scores injured, thousands homeless and economic damage in the billions of dollars.

Untold pain and suffering.

The most powerful storm to hit Florida in 12 years — packing winds of up to 145 mph — Charley twisted and tore at Lee County and its barrier islands Friday afternoon before roaring into Charlotte Harbor.

With an estimated 250,000 structures damaged in Lee County — including many that were wiped off the map — Pine Island residents returned home Saturday to major destruction.

U.S. Army National Guard troops began helping Fort Myers police patrol the streets Saturday night as a curfew went into effect.

Frustrated residents of Fort Myers Beach and Lee County's other barrier islands — ordered to stay on the mainland — clamored for details on when they could go home.

■ See **CHARLEY** B2



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Celia Carr reacts to the loss of her home and friends at a mobile home park off Florida Street on Saturday in Punta Gorda. Two of her neighbors died in the fury of the storm. Her place of work also was destroyed.

SPECIAL REPORT

■ Gov. Bush visits Charlotte County
■ Punta Gorda residents dig through the rubble
■ Storm stuns homeowners in trailer parks
■ Charlotte officials, residents make do
■ Charley alters landscape on Sanibel, Captiva
■ North Captiva residents ride out the storm
■ San Carlos Island covered by a blanket of sand
■ People in Lee County still picking up the pieces
■ Schools, businesses deal with the damage
■ Coping with a post-Charley world

news-press.com/hurricane

■ More than 300 new aftermath photos
■ Regular updates on President Bush's visit today and other developments

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A Gannett Newspaper
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TODD STUBING/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Debris from a concrete table sits in front of The Charlotte Regional Medical Center on Saturday in Punta Gorda.

CHARLEY

■ Continued from B1

In Charlotte County, buildings were leveled in downtown Punta Gorda and along U.S. 41, which officials dubbed "Ground Zero."

"It's Andrew all over again," Charlotte County Emergency Management Director Wayne Sallade said. "We believe there's significant loss of life. I would hope that it would be limited to dozens, if that."

Countless homes in the county's 31 mobile home parks were torn to bits.

When Cindy Vallier returned to Crystal Lake Mobile Home Park in Punta Gorda, the bodies of the elderly couple across the road were lying in her front yard, covered in blankets.

"Every time I walk down here, there's two dead people in my driveway," Vallier, 53, said as she surveyed the twisted wreckage engulfing her home.

"Where do we go now? What do we do?" said Barbara Seaman, 69, standing by the shell of a demolished building in Punta Gorda's Windmill Village Trailer Park.

The federal government was sending a 25-member mortuary team to Charlotte to process bodies as emergency workers tried to find those trapped in the rubble as sheriffs' deputies stood guard over the dead.

Gov. Bush — who toured the area Saturday — planned to return today with his brother, President Bush, who has declared Southwest Florida a major disaster area.

As the nation gasped at pictures of the devastation on network television, Democratic presidential candidate John Kerry expressed his "heartfelt sympathies" to storm victims.

A Category 4 storm, Charley was the first hurricane to hit Lee County since Hurricane Donna, a Category 3 storm, in 1960.

Early estimates put statewide damage at $15 billion, making Charley the third costliest disaster in U.S. history behind the Sept. 11 terrorist attacks and Hurricane Andrew, which killed 26 in South Florida in 1992 and caused $20 billion in damage.

Officials put the damage estimate in Lee County at $3 billion.

More than 494,000 Florida Power & Light customers caught in Charley's path — including more than 135,000 in Lee — remained without electricity Saturday evening.

Meanwhile, another storm was brewing in the Gulf. Tropical Storm Earl gathered strength Saturday as it neared several eastern Caribbean islands and forecasters said it could reach hurricane strength by Monday.

Officials in at least three Lee County cities — Cape Coral, Sanibel and Fort Myers — ordered curfews Saturday warning residents not to be on the roads at night. The curfew for Lee County was set at 11 p.m., and ends at 6 a.m. for unincorporated Lee County and the city of Bonita Springs.

Law enforcement officials warned the orders would be strictly enforced.

Lee Schools Superintendent James Browder ordered schools closed Monday and said they may stay closed all week.

Three cities in Southwest Florida — Arcadia, Port Charlotte and Punta Gorda — were without running water, state officials said.

The Pine Island Water Association's 13,000 customers were advised to boil their water until further notice while tests are conducted to see if the storm damaged water lines.

Gov. Bush told reporters there were 1,500 National Guard troops in the area and another 5,000 on their way to provide services and security.

Fort Myers Police spokeswoman Kara Winton said the department was joined Saturday by about 50 Guardsmen who arrived in 14 Army vehicles.

"The police department will utilize both the troops and the vehicles," Winton said. "Some troops will be stationed throughout the city in the marked vehicles. Others will be paired with police officers to respond to calls for emergency service, to patrol the city's business districts, to direct traffic, to assess damage and to help remove debris."

Winton said the department also was being aided by 30 officers from the U.S. Marshal's Service who began providing assistance at mid-day Saturday.

Florida Attorney General Charlie Christ created a task force to ward off price gougers trying to take advantage of Hurricane Charley. Crist said Saturday his office had already received about 100 complaints.

U.S. Rep. Porter Goss, R-Sanibel, visited the Lee County Emergency Operations Center and praised workers for their quick, organized response.

"When you get through, tell me what the bill is and I'll help out in Washington," Goss said.

The Lee County Sheriff's Office identified the man killed in the storm as Danny Williams, 25, of North Fort Myers.

Williams died Friday when he stepped outside his home for a cigarette and was crushed by a Banyan tree.

Most stores in Lee County stayed closed Saturday. The ones that opened were flooded with customers, people wanting gasoline, food, ice.

Major property damage was reported on Captiva and Useppa islands, Lee County Emergency Management Director John Wilson said. Fifty to 70 percent of the homes incurred major damage, and some may have been destroyed, he said.

On Upper Captiva, officials estimated 25 percent of the nearly 300 homes were destroyed and 60 percent suffered major damage.

Sanibel officials said Charley cut a 400-yard swath through the middle of the island.

The Sanibel Causeway was inspected Saturday and declared safe, though a seawall under its drawbridge was washed away.

Still, residents were being told to stay off the islands.

"We're not going to allow anyone back on the islands until we find out what's going on," Wilson said.

With traffic lights out over the vast majority of the county, the Lee County Sheriff's Office urged residents to stay at home or in shelters and avoid driving unless absolutely necessary.

Twelve traffic accidents were reported in the county between midnight and 3 p.m. Saturday, including two with injuries.

Residents were told to treat every inoperable traffic light as a four-way stop.



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Power lines hang in the balance on Florida Street in Punta Gorda after being knocked over by Hurricane Charley.



TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Scott Ehlers, leader of Task Force No. 3 from Tampa Bay, which is a search-and-rescue team trained for emergency response, prepares his men to search through the rubble of the Bay Palm mobile home park on Saturday in Punta Gorda.

EDISON & FORD ESTATES

Hurricane Charley damage to historical homes minimal

BY MARK MARYMONT
Special to The News-Press

The damage to the Edison & Ford Winter Estates isn't as bad as it may look from the street.

Chris Pendleton, president and CEO of the estates, said they had a lot of trees and vegetation down in the aftermath of Hurricane Charley, "but we didn't sustain any damage to the Edison structures or the restoration. We do have a tree down on the Ford Cottage, but that's about it.

"One reason we fared so well is that for the last two years we have been aggressively pruning and removing trees around the buildings. I guess that's a good lesson when you live in an area that gets high winds, you should keep buildings free from vegetation that can cause significant damage."

Pendleton estimated they had lost about 40 percent of the botanical material on the grounds, "but of that about 60 percent are historical trees so it will cost hundreds of thousands of dollars to replace them. We will be applying to FEMA for emergency funds for the trees and the Ford Cottage."

Saturday, more than a dozen maintenance people were working on clearing a path through the estates. Pendleton said that was prelude to moving in heavy equipment, "so we can actually begin to remove the debris. Safety is our big concern now and we are trying to be very careful in the work.

This is a relatively slow time of year for tourists, but Pendleton said temporarily closing the estates would still impact their bottom line, "because every day we are closed hurts and, this time of year, we see about 500 people daily."

Tours of the estates aren't likely to be offered until at least Wednesday.

"It could take a long time to get the paths cleared," Pendleton said. "The bottom line is that people should call our main number, 334-7419. Unless a person answers, you can count on us being closed."

Residents cautiously discover, assess damage

BY TANYA SOMAROO
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Residents of Burnt Store Marina, one of the biggest housing developments near the Charlotte-Lee County line, ventured out on bikes and golf carts Saturday morning to survey the damage.

A large tree blocked the exit to Burnt Store Road and forced residents to use the entrance lane for both purposes. Some of the condominiums had walls and roofs missing.

"It beat us pretty good," said Joe Carriveau, who lives at Harbour Towers and works at the marina. "You can see right into that guy's bedroom," he said as he pointed past boats with shredded sails to a gaping hole in a condo where the sliding door used to be.

Carriveau rode out the storm at home.

"I've never seen anything like it, and I probably never will. I won't stay here again," Carriveau said.

He started his day Saturday by removing the wreckage of the door from the dry storage dock and picking up displaced palm trees.

"You don't know where to start," Carriveau said as he surveyed the damage.

"Everybody's pool cage is gone," said Peggy Love, 66. "It's either destroyed or gone."

Love stayed at her home with nine friends and neighbors.

"We were holding the glass sliding door because it was buckling. We had a card table up against it," said Cherie Hamner, who stayed at Love's home.

Shattered roofing tiles were scattered over the area.

"They were like bullets going by," Hamner said.

Her condo and a 36-foot Catamaran she docked in the marina sustained minimal damage. Love's home also received minimal damage.

A houseboat that was converted into a yacht-sales office was not as fortunate. Winds tilted the small building onto its side. Other boats were rammed up onto the docks or partially submerged in the water.

"This place is a mess, but overall we're lucky out here," said Jon Oemig, 57, as he toured the neighborhood in a golf cart with his wife, Roseann.

Most of the landscaping was flattened or ripped out of the ground. Some large palms with braces still attached were tilted over. But a landscaping truck was already on duty picking up debris Saturday afternoon.

The couple was most worried about the storm surge. They sought higher ground at the Ventura Lakes clubhouse near the Charlotte County Airport and returned to find their home nearly unharmed.

"We really lucked out," Roseann Oemig said.

Sandy Clayton had to check on two things at Burnt Store Marina on Saturday — the new boat she bought last week and the new condo she bought last month at Grand Isle.

Clayton, 48, waited out the storm in her condo at Vista del Sol.

"It was scary," said Clayton, who moved here from Virginia two years ago. "The water was coming in through the sliders."

Clayton hid in the laundry room storage closet and piled pillows and sofa cushions around herself.

In the morning, she climbed on her golf cart and headed to the boat slip. The winds stripped away her boat cover, but the vessel remained on the boat lift with only a bent sun canopy. Clayton counted herself among the fortunate. Two slips down, a boat was partially submerged under the water.

There was no power in the area, so Clayton climbed the seven flights of stairs to her new condo to check for damage. The condo was nearly untouched. Two panels of screen covering the balcony were slashed. The culprit appeared to be the smashed roofing tile.

At Burnt Store Lakes, Carol and Lee Sieger came out of their shuttered home to find their pool cage in their pool. They had moved into the home six weeks ago.

The fence and some of the soffits were gone. They had no power and were not sure if it was safe to drink the water that was coming out of their tap.

"We found someone else's pool cage here," said Carol Sieger, 59, as she looked at the tangled screen and aluminum piled up on her pool deck. "We think this is all ours."

Lee Sieger, 60, used a battery-powered drill to dismantle the pool cage and remove it from the pool deck. But beyond that, the newcomers from Pennsylvania were not sure what to do with the debris.

The county will remove debris placed on the curb. But homeowners are responsible for putting it there and removing any fallen trees from their property.

"Our neighbor said, 'Welcome to paradise,'" Lee Sieger said. "We've been working so hard since we got here. When does paradise start?"



TODD STUBING/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Lois Bailey of Punta Gorda rides past the remains of the River Haven mobile home park on Burnt Store Road on Saturday in Punta Gorda.



TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Jeanie Mikutis looks through some of the remains of her antiques Saturday at the Harbour Inn Antique Mall in Port Charlotte.

Antiques washed away into history

BY CHRIS WADSWORTH
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For future reference, antique glassware and hurricanes don't mix. That's what Gloria LaCourse discovered as she picked through the remains of her booth at the Harbour Inn Antique Mall on U.S. 41 in Charlotte Harbor.

"We knew this place would be gone," LaCourse said. "(Hurricane Charley) was coming up the Peace River and we knew it would hit."

Hit, and hit hard.

Much of the adjacent Harbour Inn Motel was destroyed — roofs gone, walls down, devastation. At the two-story building that housed the booths of 50 area antique dealers, Charley blew out all the windows and rampaged through the aisles.

Display cases were upended, furniture soaked, beautiful depression glass, fruit bowls and kitschy kitchen clocks — smashed together in muddy puddles of broken pottery and rainwater.

Phil Wilson, a local Realtor, estimated he lost at least $10,000 worth of merchandise from his booth.

As he loaded a large stuffed ostrich into his truck, Wilson had a look of shock frozen on his face.

"Everything I own, everything is ruined," he mumbled over and over. "I don't even know where to begin."

Inside the shop, Elizabeth Delpaine gasped when she saw the damage at the booth her mother has operated the past four years.

Her mother is safely up north, but Delpaine rode out Charley at her home a few miles away in Port Charlotte. There, she had the unique experience of being in the eye of the hurricane.

"It was incredible. The whole house lit up," Delpaine said. "I've never seen anything so bright and so vivid. My ears popped. It was amazing."

Less amazing was the mess in the 8-year-old antiques mall. The owners of the facility were up north during the storm, and tenants speculated on the mall's future as they salvaged what they could from the ruins. Many already had made up their minds.

"God was telling me to quit," said Jeanie Mikutis, as she picked up a broken bisque figurine from the floor.

"This is the end of this place," LaCourse said. "The next thing is the bulldozers."



TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Ali Rowand, 45, and her pet toy poodle, Bunny Sue, look over the remains of the Harbour Inn on Saturday afternoon in Port Charlotte.

"This is the end of this place. The next thing is the bulldozers."

■ **Gloria LaCourse,**
owner of a booth at the Harbour Inn Antique Mall

AROUND CHARLOTTE COUNTY

Saving family portraits

In Port Charlotte, the houses turned upside down reflected lives turned upside down.

At the Port Charlotte Village, the Gaithers home had a poignant touch among the shattered remnants of their mobile home.

Four family pictures were propped against a turned-over TV, a toppled stool and a fallen lamp, almost as if in defiance of the destruction.

They were: a baby portrait; a closeup of a young teenage girl; a wedding picture of a young couple in candlelight; and a family photo of seven women and a man, perhaps seven siblings.

Members of a family forever changed by Charley.

Bizarre, comic moments

There were many ironic, bizarre and even comic moments when walking through the aftermath of Charley.

One easy chair stood upright in the midst of what almost couldn't be identified as a home, as if waiting for someone to casually take a seat.

The eerie sound of vertical blinds slapping against broken windows and broken doors opening and slamming in the breeze in an otherwise deserted, devastated neighborhood.

A sign reading "Caution Adults At Play" amid twisted metal debris and trees bent like horizontal candy canes.

Waiting it out

Marjorie Dutton, 86, remembered what happened as Charley passed over her shelter at the Maple Leaf Golf and Country Club in Port Charlotte.

"Everybody was having a wonderful time, playing cards in groups and chatting," she said. "And all of a sudden the lights went out and that's all she wrote. Things began to roar and fly and I thought, 'Oh no, it can't be.' "

Now, she sat waiting for the Red Cross to bus her to a school that would serve as a temporary shelter.

"I've lost things that mean something to me," she said. "We've got to find other places to go."

— Mary Wozniak



TODD STUBING/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Bill Foster of Port Charlotte takes a break Saturday from taping up windows on his mother-in-law's trailer at Parkhill mobile home park on Burnt Store Road in Punta Gorda. Jeanette Biddle, his mother-in-law, stayed with his family in Port Charlotte during the storm.

'Downtown is going to be a shame'

Punta Gorda takes catastrophic hit

BY OSVALDO PADILLA
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The surreal views of ubiquitous destruction along the streets of Punta Gorda underscore the hard truth: The city will never be the same.

As emergency crews continue to clear power poles off streets, search for bodies and tabulate damage costs, shocked residents were taking stock of how Hurricane Charley's fury and destruction changed their lives.

The harshest reality was that 10 people were confirmed dead throughout Charlotte County.

Thousands of people through Punta Gorda Isles and downtown Punta Gorda have been forced from their homes, apartments and condos. Thousands more were without power and water — probably for weeks — and phone service.

A curfew is in place from 9 p.m. until 6 a.m. until residents learn differently. Life is definitely not the same.

Damage is particularly bad in the numerous mobile home and trailer parks.

"Such devastation, my God," said Mary Tyson, 40, as she looked at scattered piles of twisted aluminum and wood that were homes just two days ago at her mobile home park off Florida Street.

Two people died in the park. Dozens of others lost their homes and possessions.

"I lost my home and my job all in eight hours," said Celia Carr 54, a resident in the park. The Blossom Shop in downtown Punta Gorda where she worked also was demolished.

As Carr surveyed the wreckage throughout the park, she also mourned the loss of her neighbors, Gordon and Joanne Hawkins.

She tried to persuade them to evacuate. They stayed.

"He has Alzheimer's. She said she wasn't going to leave," Carr said.

According to Carr, the Hawkins' bodies were found lying across the street from what was left of their homesite just after the storm passed.

The landscape and the architecture throughout Punta Gorda have blown away.

"Downtown is going to be a shame because it was so quaint," a tearful Nancy Gipson said.

Damage downtown varied widely. Some buildings, with the town's signature murals, are practically unscathed, while demolished businesses were next door. Even a simple landmark, such as the Supertest gas station at the split on U.S. 41, is gone. Downtown was part of a chilling pattern:80 percent of the county suffered damage.

Trucks were pulled into abandoned gas stations to sell supplies or to give out basic necessities such as bottled water.

Homeowner Mike Gambino looked angrily at the damage around his home on Traube Avenue downtown. He said the rebuilt historic district may lose much of its appeal.

"They're not going to get the traditional Punta Gorda," Gambino said. His 98-year-old home suffered extensive damage.

National Guard troops strapped with automatic weapons and wearing camouflage uniforms and matching helmets were guarding Charlotte Regional Medical Center. All three of the city's hospitals are closed after the storm blew out windows, smashed in doors and blew away pieces of roofs. Field hospitals have been set up in the parking lots to treat walk-in patients.

Residents were wondering "When will power, water be restored? When will their homes be rebuilt? When will their phones work?"

No one is sure how long the gargantuan effort will take.

Emergency managers were quick to point out that just two days after the storm, they have been able to mobilize thousands of workers from throughout the state.

"We're in as good shape as we can be for the shape we're in," said Wayne Sallade, emergency management director for Charlotte County.

Port Charlotte residents return to decimated city



■ Family pictures are lined against damaged items in a home in the Village on Kings Highway in Port Charlotte.



PHOTOS BY GARTH FRANCIS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Jim Ramie of Melbourne carries salvageable goods from his father-in-law's demolished trailer in Palmetto mobile home park in Port Charlotte.

BY MARY WOZNIAK
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Throughout Port Charlotte on Saturday, people returned to ravaged homes, finding pieces of their everyday lives mingled with the debris of disaster.

Hurricane Charley cut a swath from Southwest Punta Gorda to northeast North Port, claiming at least 15 lives at last count.

At the Port Charlotte Village on Kings Highway, only a few of the 435 mobile homes were livable, said Eric Rader, maintenance supervisor.

"I wasn't expecting this. I wasn't expecting this at all," Rader said.

Metal roofs were peeled back like sardine cans. Pieces of white PVC were twisted around palm tree trunks.

On the grass, a clothes washer lay next to two boxes each of glass silver Christmas balls — intact. A can of Maxwell House decaf coffee lay 10 feet from a Mr. Coffee machine.

Just down the street, there was the potential that the Maple Leaf Golf and Country Club, with 1,112 units, could be declared a disaster area, said John Bradley, general manager. In any case, the mobile home park was currently unlivable. "There is no water, no electricity," he said.

Not to mention that barely a mobile home was left standing.

Iroquois Lane looked like a plane had crash-landed in the middle of it and broken apart. Pieces of roofs, aluminum, insulation, polyurethane and tin were scattered everywhere.

"My God, this is unbelievable," said Ed Brzozowski, who works on the grounds.

A metal pole pierced the side of a home like a javelin. Streets in one area were flooded a foot deep. Other spots looked like dumpsters had been turned over.

The park has 2,000 residents, 60 percent of them Canadian. But 80 percent of them are snowbirds, Bradley said.

When Charley hit with its 145-mph winds, the 250 remaining people huddled in two shelters inside the community, built to withstand a Category 1 hurricane.

They weren't expecting to hear parts of their mobile homes breaking apart and bouncing down the streets. Nor were they expecting to hear part of the roof of one of the shelters rip off in the Category 4 winds.

Incredibly, there were no fatalities or injuries, he said.

The Red Cross was taking the remaining residents to a school serving as a shelter until new living arrangements could be made.

But the shelter wouldn't take pets. This was the last straw for Sherry Kicklighter.

She stood clutching her little brown dog, Skittles, with tears streaming down her checks. She carried a blue plastic bag with her belongings.

"I lost my car. My house. I don't have any family. All I have is me and my dog," she said.

An insurance adjustor visiting the park offered to give her a place to stay.

At Palmetto Mobile Home Park, the only item of furniture left standing in the home of Gary Paro, 57, was a kitchen table and chairs.

Everything else was upside down.

"He wanted to stay. Thank God he didn't," said Paro's daughter, Terri Ramie, of Melbourne. "We would have found all of this on him."

Paro had just moved into the place last September and had no insurance.

"It couldn't have been more direct," he said, shuffling through the hurricane debris in brown corduroy slippers. "It's too much."



GARTH FRANCIS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Gary Paro, 57, pauses a moment as he salvages anything left in his Palmetto Mobile Home Park trailer in Port Charlotte. Paro, who has lived in the trailer for about a year, does not have insurance.

Mobile-home owners rummage through rubble

Charley showed no mercy to Punta Gorda park

BY CHRIS WADSWORTH
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Ken McMaster spent much of Saturday rooting around in the rubble looking for pieces of shredded metal he could use to patch holes in his home. Duct tape would act as a sealer for the makeshift plugs.

"There's bound to be some (of the right size) in the park," said McMaster, 67. "I've got four holes in the roof."

McMaster was one of the few homeowners to return to the Bay Palms Mobile Home Park off Marion Avenue in hard-hit Punta Gorda. Like most mobile and manufactured homes in the area, they saw no mercy from Hurricane Charley when it roared through Friday afternoon.

Mary Henrique, another Bay Palms resident, was initially very calm as she stood on her torn-apart lanai, surveying the debris field that was her neighborhood. Despite her damaged roof, her torn-up plants and her missing screened enclosure, Henrique was thankful.

"I couldn't believe it was still standing," she said. Even more remarkable, glasses still stood on her bar, figurines remained upright on tables and family pictures hung safely on the walls. "Here they sit — dry as a bone," she said.

But moments later, Henrique's cool demeanor slipped a bit.

A search-and-rescue team from Tampa, part of Task Force Florida, entered the park — the first official sign of help anyone there had seen. With their helmets askew, wearing heavy protective vests and carrying high-tech rescue equipment, the half-dozen men from the Tampa area made their way through the stalks of twisted metal.

Henrique made a beeline for them.

"Is someone going to tell us where we can get water?" she pleaded, tears in her eyes.

The out-of-towners did the best they could to answer her questions and console her. Then they moved on, focused, but a bit dumbstruck.

"They took a heck of a shot," said Scott Ehlers, the task force's team leader.

Most of the neighbors mingling in the wreckage said they planned to repair and rebuild, not giving up on their little piece of Punta Gorda paradise.

Most, but not all.

"We like it here, but if another one comes, we're leaving," said Robert Henrique, Mary's husband. "We might move back to Maine. A nor'easter is a lot easier than this."

Winds mangle planes, hangars

BY CHRIS WADSWORTH
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Cheri Harmon walked among the rubble of the Charlotte County Airport, searching for items blasted from the hangar where she and her husband, Sam, kept their beloved Piper Cherokee.

Suddenly she bent down and pulled a dark khaki cloth from a puddle. It was her husband's flight suit.

"It's awful," Harmon said, struggling to describe the devastation around her. She finally settled on a tried-and-true description. "It looks like a war zone."

The airport in Charlotte County sustained terrible damage as Hurricane Charley plowed through Friday afternoon. Hangars crumpled under the intense winds, their great sheets of metal siding tossed blocks away, wrapping themselves around palm trees like foil.

The small planes, no longer protected, rolled and tumbled across the airport's fields. Many came to rest balanced on their wings, their nose, their tails, like gymnasts suddenly frozen in mid-cartwheel.

According to airport officials, there are normally about 250 planes housed in the many metal hangars that line the concrete tarmac. A few dozen owners flew their aircraft out before the storm, but most were caught off guard by Charley's strength and sudden turn toward Charlotte County.

"There wasn't enough time to do that," Cheri Harmon said. "There was nothing we could do."

So the Harmons and scores of other airplane owners just hoped for the best.

They got the worst.

"I've seen only one plane that didn't look like it was damaged," said Gary Quill, the airport's executive director. "It was like a tornado times 10,000."

Skip Hill of Punta Gorda lost two aircraft — an ultralight and a KR-2 experimental plane he built. Neither made it through the hurricane.

"The ultralight is just a twisted ball of metal and fabric," said Hill, 64. "The KR-2 is broken in half. They're just gone."

Hill estimated the two planes were worth more than $20,000. That's money gone with the winds of Charley because Hill carried no insurance.

Airport officials estimate damages at the facility could approach $40 million.

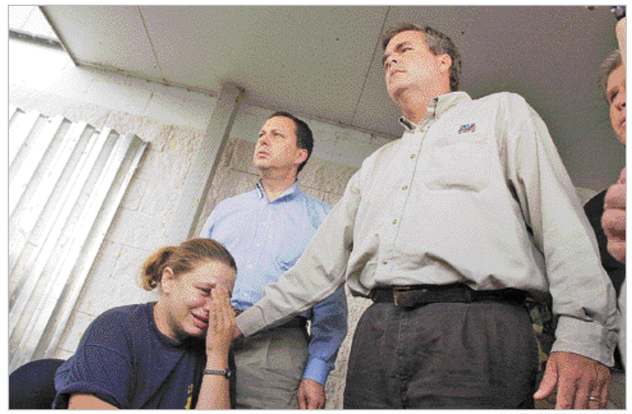
As for the Harmons, they found their Piper Cherokee about a hundred yards from the hangar, remarkably intact. The $60,000 aircraft had a few dents and dings, a broken prop and a smashed windshield, but at least it still looked like an airplane.

"How it got there in one piece is a miracle," Sam Harmon said.



TERRY ALLEN WILLIAMS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Sam Harmon of Fort Myers walks toward his plane Saturday at the Charlotte County Airport. The Piper Cherokee 180 (the yellow plane in the background) was blown more than 200 feet from its hangar.



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Gov. Jeb Bush comforts Vanessa Snyder, who lost the roof of her Punta Gorda home, on Saturday outside Charlotte County Emergency Operations. At center is Michael Brown, director of FEMA.

Help is on the way, Bush vows

5,000 more National Guard troops coming to the area

BY OSVALDO PADILLA
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Florida Gov. Jeb Bush and his two top officials visited devastated Charlotte County on Saturday and said help has arrived and more is coming for residents of Charlotte County.

"FEMA (Federal Emergency Management Agency) is mobilizing along with state rescue crews as well as other communities' rescue crews to restore normalcy as quickly as possible," said Bush at a news conference on Saturday afternoon in Punta Gorda .

County crews have set up a morgue at the riverfront as they continue to search for people who died during destructive Hurricane Charley. There were 10 unconfirmed deaths throughout Charlotte County, according to emergency director Wayne Sallade.

The Category 4 storm ravaged Punta Gorda and Port Charlotte after storming through the area Friday afternoon.

"We have taken a crushing blow in Charlotte County," Sallade said. "We have met our Andrew, and we will win."

According to Bush, there are 1,500 National Guard troops in the area and an additional 5,000 are coming. The governor said lessons learned during Hurricane Andrew already have been applied in this case to bring service and security to people quickly.

Several dozen officers from the Broward County Sheriff's Office gathered at about noon at the Emergency Operations Center. Florida Department of Law Enforcement and Highway Patrol officers also began to arrive Saturday afternoon.

Emergency crews continued to work their way into decimated neighborhoods filled with leveled homes, fallen power poles, downed trees and pieces of lumber, aluminum and tile. There is no cost estimate regarding the damage, but the governor said it is clear the cost is in the billions of dollars.

Charlie Crist, attorney general for the state, said his office already has received about 100 complaints about business owners illegally raising their prices for necessary items. Crist said his office would pursue price gougers.

"One thing we'll not let happen is for victims to be victimized."

Residents get trapped on island

BY ALISON KEPNER
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When Kevin Melvin and his family decided to ride out Hurricane Charley in their Upper Captiva home Friday, they were expecting a Category 1 storm with a projected landfall near Tampa.

When Charley suddenly strengthened and aimed its course at Lee County's barrier islands, they had no time to evacuate.

Melvin's family joined that of friend and fellow islander Jeff Henderson. They bunkered down in an interior room, taking mattresses for extra protection.

"It wasn't fun," Melvin said Saturday. "You'd look out and there'd go a roof, a top of a house, a golf cart."

The worst of the storm likely lasted 15 minutes, Henderson said.

"But it seemed like an hour or two," he said. "It was crazy."

Upper Captiva received the brunt of the wrath of Charley, whose eye passed over the bridgeless island. All 300 homes on the island suffered at least some damage.

Henderson's home had minor damage, but Melvin's lost part of its roof. Melvin's parents' home is a total loss, he said.

Twenty-seven people rode out the storm on the island, which is about 4 1/2 miles long and 1/2 mile wide. Some of those remaining on the island Saturday told harrowing stories of how they survived.

About a dozen residents camped out in the Upper Captiva Fire District station, the only building on the island not to suffer any damages, but others attempted to ride out the storm in their own homes.

One man almost did not make it.

Islander Scott Gilbert was alone in his house on the north end of the island when 140-mile per hour winds began to buckle the home's walls. Believing flight to the fire station was his only chance for survival, Gilbert hugged his cat close and began fighting his way to the station, Fire Chief Richard Pepper said.

Graciously, the eye of the storm soon moved in, giving him a much-needed break in the winds and allowing him to run towards the station. He was almost at the door when the backside of the storm hit.

Those inside fought to open the door against the strong winds and pull him — and the cat clawing the side of his face — inside to safety, Pepper said.

Home owner Hart Kelley also had a close call.

Kelley and a friend were communicating with Pepper via radio when the storm blew in one of the windows of Kelley's home. The two fled to an interior bedroom, where they struggled to hold the door shut all while staying in radio contact with the fire station, Pepper said.

"We were giving them a count down" of when the storm would pass, the chief said. "We'd say '10 more minutes,' and they'd say 'You told us that 15 minutes ago.'"

Pepper did not plan to ride out the storm on the island, either. He returned to the station from checking for remaining residents to hear the Category 4 storm upgrade.

"It just exploded, and we were stuck then," Pepper said.

He called the U.S. Coast Guard to request a helicopter to help them evacuate, but winds already were too high for the chopper to fly.

"That's when we knew we were in trouble," he said, showing his log book where he wrote "We're in big trouble" at 1:40 p.m.

Saturday, he felt lucky to be alive and ready to brace for a long clean-up. He expects it could be more than a month before power is restored to the island.

But before then, he has more immediate worries. Septic tank back-ups have allowed sewage water to leak onto the streets, making bacterial infections the greatest concern.

He expects much-needed supplies, such as fuel, water, food and cleaning agents, to arrive today as well as help from the National Guard.



RICARDO ROLON/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ The remains of a North Captiva home Saturday afternoon show the devastating effects of Hurricane Charley.

Barrier islands bear brunt of storm

BY ALISON KEPNER
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Lee County's barrier islands are a ghost of their former selves — million-dollar homes leveled, age-old trees toppled and a new 400-yard pass cut through the middle of North Captiva.



RICARDO ROLON/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ The roof of a stilt home on North Captiva lies next to the first-floor foundation on Saturday afternoon. The effects of Hurricane Charley were visible throughout the island.

That posh, exclusive island suffered the worst of Hurricane Charley's wrath when the Category 4 storm ripped through Southwest Florida on Friday. Every one of its 300 homes was damaged with a quarter of the houses destroyed, Upper Captiva Fire District Chief Richard Pepper assessed Saturday.

Another 60 percent suffered major damage while the remaining 15 percent had minor damage, he said.

Throughout Lee County, 250,000 homes are believed to have seen at least some damage at a cost of about $3 billion, according to a Lee County property appraiser estimate.

Although authorities continued to restrict all access to the islands Saturday, a few residents sneaked on by boat. Those who ventured out witnessed the devastation Charley left behind.

One North Captiva home facing Captiva Pass lost its front wall and roof, revealing a view of the kitchen, where a microwave, refrigerator and grocery-stocked pantry remain. The left corner exterior walls are all that is left of another house, whose interior is in shambles underneath a collapsed roof.

Aside from the widespread structural damage is a forever-altered landscape. Mature trees that once cloaked the island are leveled, and the storm cut a shallow pass through the island where a 100-yard beach and a long stretch of Australian Pines once stood.

"This island has now changed forever," Pepper said.

Hurricane Charley's seemingly subjective wrath wiped out some homes while neighboring structures remain with little apparent exterior damage.

On Cabbage Key, a small green house appears unscathed while a rental cottage nearby lost its second floor and roof.

On Useppa Island, the winds folded boat slips. A 20-foot sailboat sunk, and the tip of another is visible sticking out of the water nearby. Stilts are all that remain of most of the historic fish shacks west of Little Wood Key in Pine Island Sound.

But not everything is lost. North Captiva homeowners Joe and Barbara Miklavcic are among the lucky ones. Their Seair Lane home suffered only only minor damage.

"The trees are all gone around it, and the house is still sitting in the middle of it," Joe Miklavcic said.

The couple, who had evacuated to the mainland, returned Saturday, expecting to find a pile of rubble.

"We thought it was just totally gone," Joe Miklavcic said.

Most island property owners were not as lucky. The historic "Ding" Darling house, owned by artist and Captiva resident Bob Rauschenberg, lost much of its roof. Five of the 10 structures on Rauschenberg's property suffered some damage, said complex manager Matt Hall.

Rauschenberg, who rode out the storm in his Captiva home, already had helicoptered off the island, but Hall returned Saturday to assess the damage. He was most upset about the lost yellow pine of the Darling house.

"This breaks my heart," he said. "I can't get that wood."

Also on Captiva, most South Seas Resort buildings sustained some kind of damage whether it was roofing that peeled away or windows that blew out. Downed trees covered the property. Charley also folded the golf driving cages and twisted the mast of a sailboat around the boat slips.

But general manager Chris van der Baars, who sneaked onto the island by boat Saturday, was pleased the damage was not worse.

"It doesn't look like any building has sustained structural damage," van der Baars said. "Some were absolutely untouched."

Those included the Kings Crown Restaurant, which was the original plantation house built in 1904.

"We would have wept many tears if that was destroyed," van der Baars said.

The resort management relocated 1,000 guests and 500 employees because of the storm threat. Van der Baars made arrangements with authorities for 40 of his essential employees — tree trimmers, landscapers, security and the chef — to report to work today. They know the resort best and are the most qualified to clear the roads and make repairs, safely, he said.

— Staff writer Tanya Somaroo contributed to this report.



AMANDA INSCORE/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Upper Captiva Fire Chief Richard Pepper looks over his log while recounting the events surrounding Hurricane Charley on Saturday in the island's firehouse. "This is the only building on the island with zero damage," Pepper said.

Residents can be off island for days

BY LEE MELSEK
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Fort Myers Beach residents may not be allowed back to their homes for days and the island's brisk tourist trade is shut down until further notice.

The island has no water, the sewers aren't working and 80 percent of its structures were damaged by Hurricane Charley, town officials said Saturday.

"We are trying to get the water and sewer systems up. Maybe Monday, but I don't really know,"

■ **Marsha Segal-George,** Town Manager who lost part of her home and two cars to Hurricane Charley

Even when residents are allowed back on the island they may not be able to turn on their lights and televisions for days after their return. Town officials said they were told the island's power may be out for up to a week.

Town officials met with sheriff's deputies and island firefighters Saturday trying to assess the damage and figure out when they will allow residents to return to their homes.

In the end, it was too early for specific answers.

They plan to meet again today at 7 a.m. and again at noon at the Fort Myers Beach Fire District administration building.

Town Manager Marsha Segal-George, who lost part of her home and two cars to Charley, said a lot depends on when the town can get the water running and when the county can get the sewers operating.

"We are trying to get the water and sewer systems up. Maybe Monday, but I don't really know," she said.

Until then, residents will have to wait on the mainland.

"I'm going to empty out the cooler and spread the wealth,"

■ **Kelly Pino,** Manager of Smokin' Oyster Brewery on plans to give away steaks and seafood from the restaurant's freezer to people who stayed on the island and have no food

Segal-George said a big problem now is getting the electric back on. She said Florida Power & Light has told her staff it will be anywhere from two days to a week before that happens.

"No one is coming back until the island is declared safe," Deputy TownManager John Gucciardo said. "We need building inspectors to see if we can let people go back into the condos and other places."

Fire officials said they will go street to street eyeballing homes and other buildings for any obvious structural damages before building inspectors get there.

No one had any idea how many structures are on the seven-mile-long island.

Officials also worked to get the Red Cross there to provide water and food.

Town officials made a plea Saturday to the estimated 500 people still on the island.

Please leave, they asked.

They backed up their plea by enacting a 24-hour curfew banning anyone other than emergency people on the island's main road, Estero Boulevard.

They also banned the sale of all alcohol. No businesses were open Saturday.

Lee County sheriff's Capt. Kerry Griner told town officials people have been walking up and down Estero Boulevard drinking alcohol, yelling at deputies and becoming a nuisance to emergency workers.

As Segal-George and other officials tried to plan damage assessment, a long line of cars stretched along San Carlos Boulevard at the foot of the beach bridge. Hundreds of residents sat in sweltering heat trying to get on the island to see how their homes fared.

But the sheriff's office had set up a roadblock. Tempers flared when deputies couldn't give some of the crowd specific answers to when they could return to their homes.

On the other side of the bridge, several people sipped beers at the Smokin' Oyster Brewery even though the business was closed.

Kelly Pino, the manager, said she plans to give away steaks and seafood from the restaurant's freezer to people who stayed on the island and have no food.

"I'm going to empty out the cooler and spread the wealth," she said.



RICARDO ROLON/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Bay Beach Golf Club, on Fort Myers Beach, remains inundated Saturday afternoon after the storm surge of Hurricane Charley.

Storm makes a sandy mess out of many Beach businesses

BY SARAH LUNDY
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Sand was everywhere on Fort Myers Beach on Saturday.

Hurricane Charley reduced Estero Boulevard — the main roadway through the heart of the beach — to a sandy path.

Every other business suffered some kind of damage — roof torn off, sign shattered, screens gone, parking lots buckled. Homes and resorts with swimming pools filled with salt water that stunk of rotten fish.

Two of the three Lani Kai beach bars — Spring Breakers' favorite — disappeared into the Gulf. Its bar stools and tables were swept down the street. The wind kicked the restaurants large wooden tables yards away.

"It was like something you would see from the 'Wizard of Oz,' " said Robert A. Conidaris, 46, the owner's son who rode out the storm in the hotel.

A large houseboat at Island Bay Marina on Pearl Street settled on its side. A handful of residents curious about damage to other parts of the island peddled up and down the island. Three teenagers carried surf boards in search for bigger waves on Lovers Key — anything to pass the time in an almost deserted town.

Nancy and Larry Drebes talked to their contractor Friday before deciding to stay in their new two-story beach front home on Estero Boulevard.

"Our contractor told us that he would stay here during the storm," said Nancy Drebes, 62. "And he was right."



MARC BEAUDIN/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Mark Licklider sifts through a pile of melted photographs in his charred home on Fort Myers Beach after a fire that destroyed two homes Friday.

The couple worked Saturday morning at cleaning up branches scattered across their yard. The only damage they noticed so far was a portion of material missing where the bottom floor meets the stilts.

"The main thing is it's messy now but everybody is OK," she said.

Paul McGonnell, 60, sat outside his ground-floor apartment on Primo Drive. The surge of water — or the river as McGonnell called it — smothered his apartment floor in mud, leaves and trash.

"I was sitting on my couch in knee-deep in water," he said.

Now, he just can't make himself go back inside.

"I have stuff in there that doesn't belong to me," he said. "I don't recognize some things.

"I just don't want to look in there," he added.

In the middle of all the destruction by the water, Mark Licklider, 44, watched his studio apartment burn Friday on Virginia Avenue.

"The hurricane didn't get us but the fire did," Licklider said as he took a break from digging through his burned belongings. "Everything was in here."

The fire started about 5 p.m. Friday in a house on Pearl Street that sits behind the four-unit building. The wind pushed the flames over to Licklider's studio and three other units.

He ran in five or six times to grab food and other items, including his cremated Shepherd Wolf mix, Bow, who he got after Hurricane Andrew.

"It's the damnedest things that go through your mind," he said of his last run inside to get his dog. The smoke forced him out.



RICARDO ROLON/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ A power boat lies on the back yard of a property on Saturday afternoon on Fort Myers Beach.

The other units in the building suffered some fire and smoke damage.

"We didn't have any damage until this happened," said Cherri Prather, 20, who lives in unit next to Licklider. "We were starting to feel a little bit safe."

HURRICANE CHARLEY: PUNTA GORDA, CHARLOTTE COUNTY

*** | Photo by CLINT KRAUSE, THE NEWS-PRESS | B9





PHOTOS BY STEPHEN HAYFORD/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Lawrence Kimble grabs a trash bag from his kitchen to gather salvaged items from his Southwest 20th Terrace home Saturday. Kimble and his wife were actually moving out of the home into a new town home when Hurricane Charley hit Friday. The storm generated a tornado that destroyed the roofs of several homes in southwest Cape Coral.

Residents remain strong in adversity



■ Nanci Barton and Vernon Sweigert talk about the hurricane damage to their El Dorado Parkway neighborhood Saturday. Residents of the neighborhood generally lost trees and other landscaping.



■ Toni Delligatti, visiting from New York, gets help from a man who identified himself as "Burn Out Bob" center, and Fred O'Donnell, both of Cape Coral, filling a gas container Saturday at the Circle K on Santa Barbara Boulevard. Gas purchases were limited to $10 per person with lines extending several cars and lasting 25 minutes on the average.

Despite damage, no deaths reported

BY JOAN D. LAGUARDIA
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Cape Coral was a city of survivors Saturday as lights and air conditioners were a welcome relief to the terror of Friday.

Residents who had huddled in windowless bathrooms to wait out Hurricane Charley emerged from the dark with excited curiosity to survey the damage Friday evening.

Saturday, however, they turned to the practical work of rebuilding homes and neighborhoods beat up by the Category 4 hurricane.

Although about 40,000 of 70,000 Lee County Electric Cooperative customers still had no electricity Saturday evening, the hum of generators and the growl of chain saws proved that resourceful homeowners are already rebuilding.

City officials also announced a two-week building moratorium, meaning no new permits would be processed during that time.

All because of Charley.

"We sat and watched it. Once the windows were blown out, we could see everything," said Doris Stanicki as she swept insulation and roof debris from her second-story balcony.

The roof of her 16-condo complex on Victoria Drive in Bimini Basin was ripped off and deposited in her front yard. Five rooftop air conditioners and downed trees blocked traffic in the street.

Charley battered homes around the basin, off the Caloosahatchee River in southeast Cape, and the neighborhood along Skyline north of Veterans Parkway. A tornado did damage along Skyline.

Residents around Palmetto-Pine Country Club were evacuated when broken containers of fertilizer used on the golf course created dangerous fumes.

Through the Cape, Charley randomly demolished roofs and uprooted trees. It tossed the beauty distinctive of Florida — fruit trees, garden arbors, lanai enclosures — like litter through neighborhoods.

Residents counted their blessings, however. There were no deaths in the Cape, which also escaped the expected tidal surge. Many people battled adversity with good humor.

Water seeping through Stanicki's ceiling still trickled into pots scattered throughout her condo.

"I've got pots all over the house, but nothing to cook with," she said.

Across Victoria Drive, Peter Schwartz, owner of Coral Gardens apartments, and resident Charles Kelly estimated roof repairs at about $18,000.

"When I saw that roof start to come off," said Marilyn Kelly pointing to Stanicki's complex, "I thought it was going to knock this building over."

Winds whipping across the basin also made kindling of oak trees at Four Freedoms Park and blew both roofs of Sunset Towers onto Cape Coral Parkway.

In the first-floor lobby of Sunset's south tower, Frank and Marie Carson hung pictures that fell off the wall when winds shook the seven-story building.

"That wind, it was just getting under anything it could pick up," Frank Carson said.

Most grocery chain stores were closed. The Albertsons on Pine Island Road and the Publix in Santa Barbara Center were open for part of the day but sold only shelf goods. Bottled drinks were in short supply. Ice was gone.

Gas stations along Santa Barbara were among the first restored to power late Saturday afternoon.

Small independent stores were selling whatever they could, even though their cash registers were offline.

A steady line of cars blocked the right southbound lane of Del Prado most of the morning as cars inched through the drive-up Farm Stores grocery.

Ruben Leal pulled up to the window hoping for cold drinks. He got warm Mountain Dew. He thought more convenience stores should have opened.

"Sell it," he said of items on the shelves. "Get rid of it and let it go."

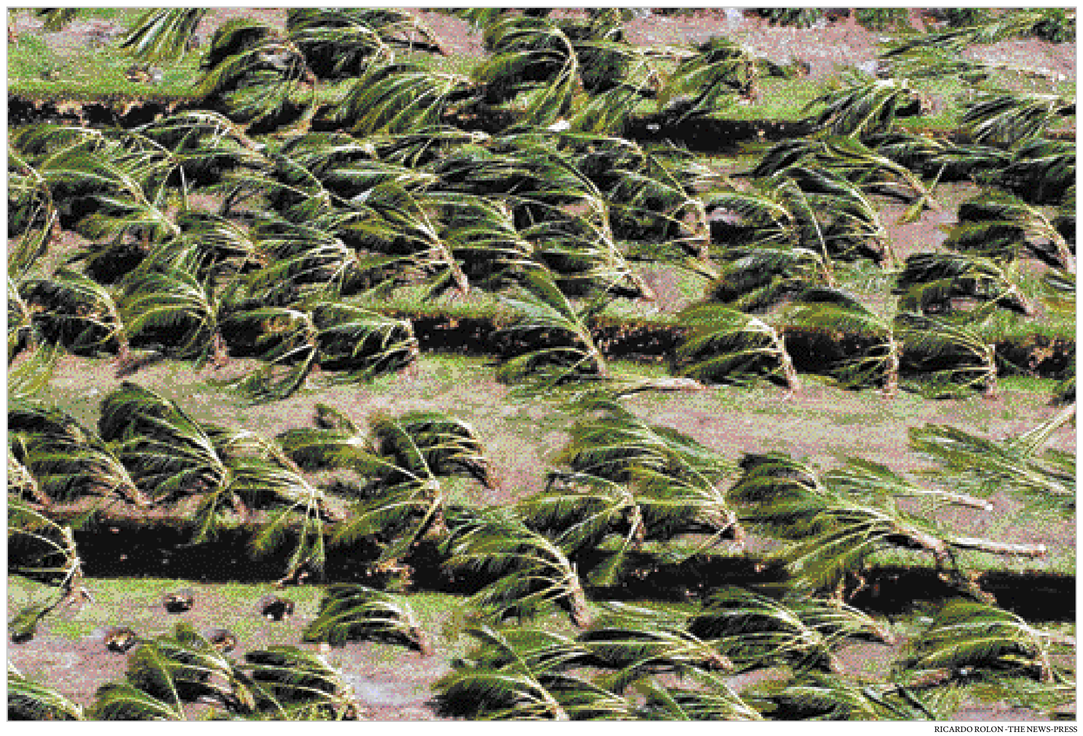
Visitors to the Cape, such as Rob Allen's family from Chico, Calif., were making the best of their ruined vacations.

His two children, Leslie, 18, and Brad, 21, and a friend, Kelsey MacKinnon, 20, enjoyed the sunny breeze as they fished in the deep blue-violet and gray Caloosahatchee off Cape Coral pier.

"We need to catch some food," said Allen, who had found mostly snacks for sale at Albertsons.

The fish weren't biting and a rental property he owned had lost a roof, but he was content to enjoy the pier and beach.

"We won't starve," he said.



RICARDO ROLON -THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Palm trees are bent sideways at a Pine Island tree farm, showing the effects of Hurricane Charley.

'... Someone came in here with a weed whacker'

Islanders facing enormous cleanup

BY KAREN QUIST
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Many of Pine Island's 9,000-plus residents returned Saturday to a different island.

Thousands of its signature pine, palm and fruit trees were toppled — "It looked like someone came in here with a weed whacker," resident Bill Fredisdorf said.

Two marinas were mangled messes, some of their expensive contents crushed.

Alden Pines Country Club — the island's only golf course community — looked like a bomb had been dropped on it.

Utility poles were snapped in half or leaning and tree limbs across the debris-strewn roads made driving dicey.

Their homes weren't the way they left them either.

At least four homes were destroyed. Few homes escaped without some kind of damage.

Dozens of mobile homes were uninhabitable.

Metal roofs were peeled from stilted homes as though they were sardine cans. Shingles were everywhere, it seemed, except where they belonged. Siding was ripped from many homes, exposing the wood frames underneath.

The island's only grocery store, Winn-Dixie, was stripped of its facade. It was still serving its customers Saturday, giving away its last water and ice to dozens of people patiently waiting in line, recounting their experiences and cataloging the damage.

Pine Islanders were left to clean up the mess without power and water, possibly for as long as two weeks.

"I have never seen it like this, not since Donna," fire inspector Jeff Roach said. "There is quite a substantial amount of damage."

Flooding was not a big issue on the island because Charley "was a direct hit," Roach said.

Pineland Marina and Alden Pines may have taken the brunt of that direct hit on the island.

Gov. Jeb Bush's helicopter flew over the marina's mangled remains at 1:45 p.m. Saturday, while its neighbors worked to clean up their own messes.

Charley tore the roof off much of the second story of the nearby Tarpon Lodge, which sits on the edge of Pine Island Sound.

Saturday afternoon's sky was visible through the ceilings of several rooms. Broken glass and plaster littered the floors. Outside, there was no sign of the two boathouses that had stood in the water since the lodge was built in 1926.

Rob Wells, who manages the lodge owned by his family, at first wasn't too worried about Hurricane Charley. He was used to Southwest Florida's flirtation with tropical weather systems.

Besides, the lodge has stood on the edge of Pine Island Sound for more than seven decades.

"I thought it would be one of the safer places to be," Wells said.

Wells left the island about noon after hearing Charley was going to be a lot worse than earlier thought. He stayed at a friend's home in Cape Coral, where he kept up on the latest track on a generator-powered television and talked via cell phone to his family on Cabbage Key, letting them know what was going to happen next.

The inn on Cabbage Key fared much better than the Tarpon Lodge, he said. It's expected to reopen within a couple of days.

Nancy Glickman, Tarpon Lodge's office manager, rode out the hurricane in her home on the other side of Pineland.

Like many on Pine Island, she said she had no intention of toughing out a Category 4 hurricane. Some said they had lost power and didn't know how strong the storm had grown or that it was heading straight for them. Others learned too late to leave the island safely.

"I wouldn't have stayed if I'd known," she said.

As she listened to the hurricane barreling through her neighborhood, toppling hundreds of pine, mango and palm trees, she expected one of the trees to come through her roof at any minute.

Instead she thinks the fallen trees — and the mounds left behind by the ancient Calusa Indians — actually helped shield her home from more serious damage.

While the storm raged, Glickman said, there were times when she thought she was going to die.

"It was one of the most frightening things I've ever experienced in my life," Glickman said.

Damage in Matlacha and St. James City was not as extensive as it was in Bokeelia on the northern end of the island, residents said.

On Saturday afternoon, GrabBag owner Ted Baer was open for business, selling still cool beverages, gallons of water and bags of melting ice in his powerless store just north of Pineland.

The south end of his store's roof was gone, and he was wondering how soon he would be able to get an insurance adjuster to assess the damage.

Daughter Mindy Baer, 18, had planned to leave for Florida State University today. Her parents would be busy dealing with their damaged business and home, so the Cape Coral High School valedictorian's move would have to wait until Wednesday, when a friend who could help her move would be back in town.

Baer doesn't get scared easily, he said, but Charley shook him up.

Baer and his family weathered Hurricane Charley in the pantry.

"We're lucky to be alive — look at the devastation," he said, pointing up the road to the Pink Citrus mobile home park.

At Pink Citrus, residents gathered around homes in various stages of destruction — some were merely knocked off their foundations, while others were crumpled beyond recognition. Many of the residents had sought shelter before the storm.

Resident Cindy Escobar, 9, read about the coming hurricane in the newspaper and told her father, Martin, that they had to go to a shelter. They spent Friday night in Fort Myers.

"I think it was a bad dream," said the Pine Island Elementary student.

On Saturday, she woke up to find that she and her father needed a new place to live.

— The News-Press staff writer Tom Hayden contributed to this article.



CHOPS HANCOCK/SPECIAL TO THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Hurricane Charley left its mark Friday not only on the ground on Pine Island, but pieces of home embedded in trees as a reminder of its power.



CHOPS HANCOCK/SPECIAL TO THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Although damaged by Hurricane Charley, the Winn-Dixie on Pine Island gave free water and ice to all those in need Saturday.

BOIL ORDER IN EFFECT

■ Pine Island Water Association customers should boil water coming out of their faucets until further notice.

That's because the company will be testing water lines for damage in the wake of Hurricane Charley, said Carol Lutz, a water plant operator.

During the five-day test period, customers will experience sporadic service, she said.

The firm provides water service to about 13,000 customers on Pine Island and the Burnt Store Road area.

For more information, call 283-1071.

news-press.com: 24-HOUR COVERAGE OF ALL HURRICANE CHARLEY NEWS AND EVENTS

THE NEWS-PRESS

MONDAY, AUGUST 16, 2004 | PUBLISHED SINCE 1884 news-press.com FINAL | 50¢

SW Floridians pick up the pieces after Hurricane Charley

STARTING OVER

Massive cleanup, repair efforts begin as relief slowly arrives to devastated areas



PHOTOS BY ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Jorge Vergara,3, plays in the wreckage of his grandparents' mobile home Sunday at the Pink Citrus Trailer Park on Pine Island near Bokeelia. Jorge lives nearby in the same park.

Cleanup, rebuilding begin as aid pours in

BY BOB RATHGEBER
brathgeber@news-press.com

After cleaning up debris, chopping up downed trees and counting their blessings, dazed and weary Southwest Floridians begin a new week, three days after Hurricane Charley changed their lives forever.

"It's as close to hell as I can think of," said Khoum Khampapha, a resident of Easy Street in Port Charlotte.

President Bush, who examined Charlotte County by air and on foot, promised swift action.

In fact, a spokesman for the Federal Emergency Management Agency said the agency has already begun handing out checks.

"There's a lot of help moving into this part of the world," the president said during his 90-minute visit.

It will be needed, for sure:

■ Almost a million people are still without power, the number changing rapidly as thousands of workers repair the lines.

■ Thousands are homeless. FEMA has asked for catastrophic housing for 10,000 people. Charlotte Emergency Management Director Wayne Sallade said he has requested a giant tent city to house people during the rebuilding effort.

INSIDE

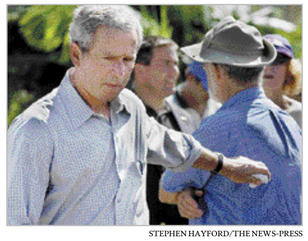
■ Supplies shortage generates frustration
■ Many exercise faith in storm-torn areas
■ Parks, beaches hit hard by storm
■ People acting neighborly after storm
■ Charley likely to delay primary election

news-press.com

■ View continuous updates on the storm's aftermath and recovery efforts.
■ **In Spanish:** Read the latest about public safety, cleanup efforts.
■ Lea las últimas noticias sobre los esfuerzos de limpieza y seguridad pública



■ Kelsey Schubert, 9, attends a church service with her mother Wendy at the Edgewater Church on Sunday in Port Charlotte.



STEPHEN HAYFORD/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ President Bush pats a Punta Gorda resident on the back as he walks past while visiting a neighborhood Sunday.

President tours area, says help on the way

BY BETTY PARKER
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President Bush flew in for a quick survey of storm-ravaged Charlotte County on Sunday, promising hurricane victims that help is on the way.

"There's a lot of help moving into this part of the world," Bush said after an impromptu sidewalk meeting with Trabue Avenue residents in downtown Punta Gorda.

"It'll take a while to rebuild it."

But federal, state and local disaster officials are working closely together to ensure meaningful help arrives quickly, he said, gesturing to his brother, Florida Gov. Jeb Bush, who accompanied the president.

"How about bringing some water with you?" one resident yelled from the back of the crowds.

Bush didn't have that, but during his 90-minute trip he and state officials said groups offering help with housing, food and water, and other needs are moving in fast.

In the meantime, Bush praised residents for holding community cookouts and helping one another as they could.

"We've seen neighbor helping neighbor out of these catastrophes. Here's where the spirit of America really shines," President Bush said on Trabue Avenue.

"Too many people lost their lives, but it's not as significant as it could have been."

Asked if political expediency had anything to do with the whirlwind trip, Bush responded, "If I didn't come they'd say I should have been here sooner."

Bush landed on Air Force One at Southwest Florida International Airport at 9:15 a.m. Without making remarks, he quickly transferred to a helicopter, accompanied by three Black Hawk choppers, and headed north along Interstate 75.

INSIDE

■ **WEATHER**
High 91 Low 76
Evening storms, 40 percent chance of rain; complete forecast

■ **NATION & LOCAL**
Democrat says fight over Goss nomination futile

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THE NEWS-PRESS

TUESDAY, AUGUST 17, 2004 | PUBLISHED SINCE 1884 news-press.com FINAL | 50¢

MORE SURVIVORS FOUND
■ Rescuers reported they found several Charlotte County residents still hiding in closets this weekend.

TOURISM TAKES A HIT
■ Lee's tourism chief predicts that Hurricane Charley's impact will be three times that of Sept. 11.

ISLANDS TO REOPEN
■ Sanibel reopens to residents at 7 a.m. Wednesday, and Fort Myers Beach will reopen two hours later.

EXTEND A HELPING HAND
■ Residents wanting to contribute to the relief effort have many options, from donating cash to time.

CLEANING UP IN THE CAPE
■ Almost 41 percent of the homes in Cape Coral suffered damage from Hurricane Charley.

TENSION MOUNTS

Angry islanders confront officials about access to homes, businesses



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Fort Myers Beach resident Charles Scofield gets upset with Fort Myers Beach Town Councilman Bill Van Duzer on Monday. Scofield who rode out the storm on the beach is upset that residents who decided to leave are not able to get on the beach to see their property.

Shelters, hospitals remain busy

BY ANDI ATWATER
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Restoration teams worked furiously Monday to return some sense of normalcy to dazed and displaced residents, but many islanders — still prohibited from seeing their homes — are frustrated and angry.

Thousands of Fort Myers Beach residents and business owners have been thwarted from going onto the island since Hurricane Charley damaged water, sewer and electric lines there.

When the Fort Myers Beach Town Council decided to prohibit access until Wednesday morning, some homeowners revolted, including a man who tried to run a roadblock and was arrested.

"We should be able to get on and off the island to get food and other things we need," said Patsy Dorsey, who stayed on the island through the storm. "The officials are going off to air-conditioned motels off the island every night but we can't go and come. I feel like a secondclass citizen."

Nearly a thousand Sanibel residents jammed Bishop Verot's auditorium to learn they could see their homes Wednesday.



DANIEL BARRY/SPECIAL TO THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Volunteer Nicole Herzing, of Fort Myers, sorts through donations at Miromar Outlets in Estero on Monday. An outpouring of relief supplies was dropped off at the outlets during a drive organized by Meridian/Fort Myers Broadcasting.

Property insurance to jump

BY JOAN D. LAGUARDIA
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Homeowners who think they know the deductible on their property insurance policy could be in for a shock as their deductibles jump thousands of dollars.

Because of Hurricane Charley's magnitude, insurance companies are permitted to shift from fixed-dollar deductibles to an amount that is 2 to 5 percent of a home's value.

A typical policy for a $100,000 home, for example, would have a fixed deductible of $500. However, that deductible would jump to $5,000 on a 5 percent policy.

"Because it is a named event, figuring in how much you are going to pay on your deductible doeschange," said Bob Lotane.

SPECIAL REPORT

■ Property values could be reappraised
■ Cape damage at $305 million
■ Snowbirds returning to assess damage
■ Charlotte High athletic facilities destroyed
news-press.com/hurricane
■ **Info exchange:** Use our Web site to help find friends, family or neighbors, or to ask about the condition of your home. We'll attempt to both e-mail you the answers and share them for all readers to see.
■ **All-day updates:** Get the latest on access, openings, supplies, power and more
■ **Latest photos:** More than 600 images of Hurricane Charley's aftermath
■ **In Spanish:** Read the latest about public safety, cleanup efforts.
■ *Lea las últimas noticias sobre los esfuerzos de limpieza y seguridad*

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A Gannett Newspaper
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THE NEWS-PRESS

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 18, 2004 | PUBLISHED SINCE 1884 news-press.com FINAL | 50¢

Mammoth cleanup looms for Sanibel, Fort Myers Beach

LONG ROAD AHEAD

Public safety director says it will take three to five years for Lee to recover



STEPHEN HAYFORD/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Tony Douglass, 19, shoves tree branches down a rooftop on Tuesday, while his father, Fred Douglass, continues to saw an Australian pine. Douglass Contracting approached Sam Tant, the owner of the home on Pine Island Road and Pompano Avenue, about removing the trees that fell on the home during Hurricane Charley. "We're just trying help people out," Fred Douglass said. "If they can afford it, we charge it. If they can't afford it, we do it for less. I'm really just charging what it costs me."

BY BOB RATHGEBER
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Massive cleanup and recovery efforts continued Tuesday in Southwest Florida, and officials said it will be a long, long haul.

But for thousands, today is a new beginning.

They get to go home.

About 112 hours after Charley first touched land on Captiva last Friday, island residents were to head back to Sanibel, Captiva and Fort Myers Beach.

At 7 a.m. the first cars were to be waved across the Sanibel Causeway, bringing an end to a gut-wrenching wait.

Then two hours later, Fort Myers Beach residents were expected to be allowed to return.

Many residents there will find storm surge and wind damage to their homes and businesses and begin the dirty cleanup work that other neighborhood started Saturday morning.

John Wilson, Lee's director of public safety, said Tuesday it would take anywhere from three to five years for the county to recover from the disaster.

Trying to speed up the process, Health and Human Services Secretary Tommy Thompson and Homeland Security Secretary Tom Ridge visited Lee and Charlotte yesterday.

Survivors send word to relatives

Families reunite with kin in Charlotte County

BY DENISE L. SCOTT
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Ramond Turpin of Victory Gardens, N.J., could imagine only the worst.

He had seen the horror of Hurricane Charley on television, but he hadn't heard from his daughter.

She and her husband have a home in Burnt Store Isles, in the heart of Charley's path through Punta Gorda.

With each passing day, more gut-wrenching thoughts invaded his mind.

"The next day, you get more nervous and jerky," Turpin said. "When I called the Red Cross, they said, 'How old are they?' My heart sunk. I thought they were looking in the morgue."

But all ended well Tuesday afternoon. For the first time since Charley crashed through Southwest Florida on Friday, Turpin heard her voice.

"We're fine, we're fine," Theresa Lacktis said, straining to be heard through breaks in cell-phone service. "I was trying to call you but could never get through."

Lacktis, 50, was weary but relieved to finally talk to her father on a borrowed cell phone.

She was surprised her father was so frantic to find her.

("He called the state police, my work ...," Lacktis whispered to a nearby eavesdropper.)

"We're all OK, that's what's important."



GARTH FRANCIS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Tower workers repair a damaged communications tower from a boom truck raised over the skies of downtown Punta Gorda as a storm rolls in Tuesday afternoon.

Lee schools will be closed all this week

BY JENNIFER BOOTH REED
jreed@news-press.com

Lee County schools will remain closed for the rest of the week, Superintendent James Browder announced Tuesday.

He will announce next week's status at 5 p.m. Saturday.

Browder said 24 schools remain without electricity, 11 lost all of their food, and traffic lights are still inoperable at many intersections. Not all employees have been accounted for, either, Browder said. He urged everyone to check in with their schools or departments if they haven't done so already.

Administrators are compiling damage assessment reports and cost estimates, but Browder said he is anticipating a multimillion-dollar repair bill.

"We're hoping it isn't in the double-digit million range, but it will be in the millions," Browder said.

Meanwhile, state Rep. Carole Green, R-south Lee County, is working with other local lawmakers and state officials to get Lee County some help.

SCHOOL UPDATES

■ Canterbury will open the first day of school as planned on Monday, Aug. 23. Faculty meetings will take place this week as planned.
■ St. Francis Xavier School will open to students Thursday. Faculty and staff return today at 9 a.m.
■ Edison College's Lee and Collier campuses will open today. The Charlotte campus is closed .
■ Bishop Verot classes will resume Thursday for all students and faculty.
■ St. Michael Lutheran School will not hold orientation or classes this week. The first day of school is Monday at 8 a.m.
■ Florida Gulf Coast University faculty and staff should expect to return to work Thursday. Students scheduled to move into campus housing Thursday should wait until Friday.
■ St. Andrew School will open today. Children should bring lunch and water.

— Private schools and day care centers are encouraged to call The News-Press at 335-0350 to have their closing and reopening information published.

SPECIAL REPORT

■ Statewide death list
■ Roofing supplies could soon become scarce
■ Boca Grande took a beating
■ How to cope days after the storm
■ County-by-county storm updates
■ Repair permit requests slow to come in Cape
■ Elderly relying on kindness of others

news-press.com/hurricane

■ **Info exchange:** Use our Web site to help find friends, family or neighbors to ask them about your home. We'll attempt to e-mail you the answers and share them for all our readers to see.
■ **All-day updates:** Get the latest on access, openings, supplies, power and more.
■ **Latest photos:** Images of Hurricane Charley's aftermath.
■ **In Spanish:** Read the latest about public safety, cleanup efforts.
■ *Lea las ultimas noticias sobre los esfuerzos de limpieza y seguridad*

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THE NEWS-PRESS

THURSDAY, AUGUST 19, 2004 | PUBLISHED SINCE 1884 news-press.com FINAL | 50¢

Residents return to battered communities

HOME AT LAST

Many on Sanibel, Captiva and Fort Myers Beach are thankful the damage wasn't worse



PHOTOS BY ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Captiva resident Sherrill Sims gets a hug from neighbor Mary Bates on Wednesday as they see each other for the first time since Hurricane Charley ripped through the island. Sanibel and Captiva residents were allowed back on the island on Wednesday. Sims didn't think her home would withstand the winds and rode out the storm at a neighbor's home.

BY JENNIFER BOOTH REED
jreed@news-press.com

Anxiety had gnawed at them for days.

Finally, Wednesday, hundreds of residents of Sanibel, Captiva and Fort Myers Beach hurried through lifted barricades to see what was left of their homes.

Many lucky ones found houses largely unscathed. Others braced for a big repair bill and weeks of cleanup.

Still, residents voiced a common refrain:

"Our needs are nowhere near Punta Gorda's," said Captiva resident and business owner Gene Routh.

WELCOME BACK

On Sanibel, someone had left a plywood sign near the Chamber of Commerce: "Welcome Home. We missed you," it read in bright blue letters. On the opposite side, the authors scribbled a huge thank-you note to everyone who'd helped: fire, police, EMS, National Guard and a host of other agencies.

Though Sanibel escaped the brunt of Charley's force, the storm still took a toll on the island.

The wind transformed the Periwinkle Way shady canopy into the sad stumps of a logging camp. Homes can be rebuilt, but the familiar trees that define the island are forever gone.

"We're blessed. We did really good," said Kris Massat, of Indiana. She, her husband, 18-year-old son and son's friend stuffed their van with snacks and drinks, a generator, chain saw and battery-powered radio and sped south to see their Sanibel vacation home.



■ Randy Wertepny, left, 23, and Ryan Wertepny, 24, of West Palm Beach, pass the time playing cards while waiting to enter Sanibel on Wednesday to help their grandfather, Bob Mayden, clean up his Sanibel home. Wednesday was the first day Sanibel was open to traffic since Hurricane Charley blew through on Friday.

Fumes from generators kill 3

Carbon monoxide poisons hundreds

BY ANDI ATWATER
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Carbon monoxide poisoning from emergency generators has killed three people statewide — including a Pine Island man — and injured hundreds more as people inhale deadly fumes.

Stacee Young, 24, woke up dizzy and befuddled in her Cape Coral home at 4 a.m. Saturday and knew something was wrong.

She woke up her roommate, Susan Crawford, 27, and they stumbled their way toward the generator, humming loudly inside the women's garage.

Crawford never made it. She passed out just as she got to the gas-powered machine, collapsing onto the hot metal and sustaining burns that kept her in intensive care for days.

Young, losing consciousness several times, managed to call 911 and save three dogs and two birds before fainting outside in a ditch, her sister, Dana Miller, 29, said. One of the birds died.

SPECIAL REPORT

KEY DEVELOPMENTS

DEATHS CLIMB

■ Deaths rose to 22 on Wednesday, including a 74-year-old Lee County man who died from heat-related stress on the heart, according to state officials; Lee officials could not confirm that.

MORE HELP ARRIVES

■ The Allstate Foundation has donated $1 million. The money will be distributed by the Southwest Florida Community Foundation.

RESTORING POWER

■ LCEC plans to have power restored to Cape Coral by Friday. Workers are assessing conditions on Sanibel, Captiva and Pine Island before restoring power.
■ FPL has restored power to 152,000 customers in Lee and 27,500 in Charlotte. About 23,000 in Lee and 62,500 in Charlotte remain without power.

SCHOOLS

■ Lee's costs may climb to $20 million as district starts repairs.

CONSTRUCTION

■ New homes may have to wait as focus turns to emergency repairs.

HEALTH

■ Today's highs will be in the low 90s, but lack of a breeze will make it feel hotter. Heat-related illnesses are a serious issue, so people without power and those cleaning up and making repairs outside should take care.

ELECTION 2004

■ Lee's Philinda Young to help Charlotte, DeSoto and Hardee counties prepare for the election.

AGRICULTURE

■ Citrus and tropical fruit crops took a serious hit from the hurricane, as did clamming and horticultural nurseries.

news-press.com

■ **Info exchange:** Use our site to help find people.
■ **En español:** Lea las últimas noticias sobre el huracán Charley.

LIFESTYLES



Many pets have also become homeless due to Hurricane Charley. Shelter workers from other agencies have stepped in to help with the animals.



GO!

Fresh seafood may be in short supply at your favorite restaurant, but the solution to the problem may be as close as your nearest body of water.

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HURRICANE CHARLEY



ANDREW WEST/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Anai Perez, 3, a resident of Third Street in the Pink Citrus Trailer Park on Pine Island, surveys the world from her front window Aug. 17. The eye of Hurricane Charley blew over the park and destroyed many homes. Her home seemed to make it through pretty much unscathed.



GARTH FRANCIS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Sherry Kicklighter holds her dog, Skittles, after being kept from staying at a hurricane shelter in Port Charlotte on Aug. 14 because pets are not allowed. She lost her home and car in the Maple Leaf Golf and Country Club in Port Charlotte. Kicklighter and her dog were offered housing by someone who noticed her situation.



GARTH FRANCIS/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ Penny and Alan Mishler carry some of their belongings down a flooded and devastated row of homes in the Maple Leaf Golf and Country Club in Port Charlotte on Aug. 14. The couple plan to stay with family in Pennsylvania after Hurricane Charley damaged their home.



CLINT KRAUSE/THE NEWS-PRESS

■ George Timpf, 74, gets a kiss from his wife, Barbara, 72, outside their mobile home in the Pine Acres community off U.S. 17 in Punta Gorda on Aug. 19. The Timpfs celebrated their 50th wedding anniversary the Saturday before Hurricane Charley arrived.